COMMONWEALTH OF AUSTRALIA

Proof Committee Hansard

JOINT STANDING COMMITTEE ON ELECTORAL MATTERS

Inquiry into the 2025 federal election

(Public)

WEDNESDAY, 12 NOVEMBER 2025

KEW

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JOINT STANDING COMMITTEE ON ELECTORAL MATTERS

Wednesday, 12 November 2025

Members in attendance: Senator Grogan and Mr Burnell, Ms Campbell, Mr Laxale and Dr Ryan

Terms of Reference for the Inquiry:

That the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters inquire into and report on all aspects of the conduct of the 2025 federal election and related matters, including consideration of the following:

- assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials;
- potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour;
- the suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements; and
- the suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology.

The Special Minister of State has also asked the Committee to consider the interaction with the following:

- the implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election;
- reforms to address the ongoing threats of interference in our electoral system, both foreign and domestic; and
- the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.

WITNESSES

BACHRACH, Ms Amy, Private capacity 29

BARRETT, Susan, Volunteer Trainer and Volunteer, Team Zoe—Volunteer Team for Zoe Daniel's 2025 Campaign 1

BIRD, Ms Leonie, Private capacity 29

CHIN, Ms Jenny 'Yanli', Private capacity 1

COUGHLAN, Mr Brian, Private capacity 29

COX, Mr Simon, Private capacity 1,29

DANIEL-REID, Mr Arkin, Private capacity 1

FORDYCE, Dr Robbie, Research Lead, RECapture 18

GIBB, Ms Rosanne, Private capacity 29

GOTTLIEB, Mr Yaron, Private capacity 29

GROVES, Mr Michael, Private capacity 29

HEEMSBERGEN, Dr Luke, Research Lead, RECapture 18

LEITCH, Dr Shirley, Private capacity 29

MORAN, Mr Rodney, Private capacity 29

SELIG, Professor Steve, Private capacity 1

STEPHEN, Mr Tony, Private capacity 29

TONCICH, Mr Carlo, Private capacity 29

WADE, Mr Tim, Volunteers for the 2025 Kooyong Independent campaign 1

YANG, Dr Fan, Research Lead, RECapture 18

BARRETT, Susan, Volunteer Trainer and Volunteer, Team Zoe—Volunteer Team for Zoe Daniel's 2025 Campaign

CHIN, Ms Jenny 'Yanli', Private capacity

COX, Mr Simon, Private capacity

DANIEL-REID, Mr Arkin, Private capacity

SELIG, Professor Steve, Private capacity

WADE, Mr Tim, Volunteers for the 2025 Kooyong Independent campaign

Committee met at 09:03

CHAIR (Mr Laxale): I declare open this public hearing of the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters for its inquiry into the 2025 election. I remind members of the media who may be present or listening on the web of the need to fairly and accurately report proceedings of the committee. I would also like to a acknowledge that we are on traditional Aboriginal land of the Wurundjeri people of the Kulin nation and pay my respects to elders past, present and emerging. I thank members and senators joining us here today and thank our community members for coming today. This is the first public hearing we are holding where we are hearing directly from members of the community. You all play a very important role in our democracy. We are all very proud of our democracy here on this side of the table. I am sure you are too. There is very good reason why we have one of the most stable democracies on earth; it is because of our high participation and respected political practices.

However, we've received evidence—and it's been well reported—that there was something a little bit different about 2025. That's why we want to come and hear directly from electoral participants, community members, volunteers and voters to get their views and experiences on the public record so that this committee can consider what, if any, reforms we should recommend to the Special Minister of State and to the government.

Thank you for taking the time to attend this inquiry, in what is a much colder Melbourne than I would have envisaged before I got here. We'll now proceed to this morning's community session. Participants in the session have been invited to give a five-minute statement to the committee. I'll invite participants to come to the table one at a time to give their statement. Should you wish, I ask that you remain at the table to briefly answer any questions from the committee before we proceed to the next witness. There is a total time per participant of about 10 minutes.

Although the committee does not require you to give evidence under oath, I should advise participants that this hearing is a legal proceeding of the parliament and therefore has the same standing as proceedings of the respective houses. The giving of false or misleading evidence is a serious matter and may be regarded as a contempt of parliament. The evidence given today will be recorded by Hansard and, importantly, attracts parliamentary privilege.

I will now call our first witness. I welcome Arkin Daniel-Reid to give a brief statement, and then we might ask some questions.

Mr Daniel-Reid: 'I will rape you to death. You will be dead soon. I will kill you in a brutal way. This will be very painful. I will burn you alive with gasoline. I know where you live and when you go outside. I will wait for you. I will destroy your ugly face with a knife. You are dead.' This was an email sent to my mum's office.

To the committee, my question for you today is: was this ever normal? As the son of former community independent Zoe Daniel, I can tell you that aggression, intimidation and abuse followed us everywhere. It became so familiar that my mum, myself, dad and my 17-year-old younger sister had to become desensitised to the violent rhetoric and abuse we received. These experiences were normal at the 2025 federal election, and I felt powerless.

When I was on a 300-metre walk to get a haircut, a passerby commented on my Zoe Daniel campaign shirt, muttering, 'effing slut'. I turned my head in disbelief. The man had already walked off, as if it were normal. After a few hours at Brighton prepoll, I left to return to my car. On my way, I walked past a middle-aged man. We each exchanged a smile until, once he was behind me, he so very bravely stated, 'Your mum is a bitch,' as if it were normal.

One day, in the very midst of the campaign, I was driving my car, which was dressed in Zoe campaign stickers, along the Nepean Highway. I was then tailgated and high-beamed all the way down Hampton Street. I changed lanes and tried to distance myself but was met with the same driver, laughing and pointing at me in my rearview mirror, as if it were normal. After attending a campaign event with mum, we were walking to the car when I

noticed two people following us. I whispered to mum, 'Do you know them?' She laughed, explaining to me that they were AFP officers protecting her in the lead-up to the election because of violent threats she was receiving.

This was normal for my family. It was everyday life. After she was followed, abused, threatened and spat on, the straw that broke the camel's back for me was the doxxing of our family car. Someone took a photo of our car inside the locked electorate office carpark with the number plate left unblurred, posting it to a Facebook page. My sister is often driven to school in that very car and had become a target of some sort. As a result, Mum reported it to the AFP to be investigated, an unsettlingly common occurrence for her during the election.

The standard you walk past is the standard you accept, and the standard for the 2025 federal election was not of the level I'm willing to accept. There was no condemnation of the doxxing of our car. Rather there was a statement from the Liberal Party on behalf of Tim Wilson for my mum to 'apologise for using this very serious issue for political gain'. With no public condemnation, this standard was normalised. The suggestion that it was 'categorically false' emboldened perpetrators to continue. If we allow what happened to my mum in Goldstein to become the norm, then there is no question that candidates and their families across Australia will see their safety and security threatened, or they simply won't run because it's all too much. Candidates and their families should not have to be mentally and physically bulletproof to put themselves forward in elections.

Candidates like Tim Wilson have a responsibility to be active bystanders when they see or hear bullying or threatening behaviour in their supporter base, they must denounce it. When such conduct occurs, the candidate must be the one to uphold the values of respect, dignity and courtesy for the entire supporter group—values that sadly went missing in Goldstein at the 2025 federal election. My mum was failed by those who were complicit in allowing Mum's and my family's safety to be compromised. I recommend that the committee consider a mandatory candidate code of conduct to be implemented in some local council elections. It would outline the responsibilities of candidates in promoting a safe environment for everyone. The code must include provisions condemning hate speech, violent rhetoric and disinformation by candidates, their teams and supporters.

Committee members, my mum didn't want me to speak today, but I couldn't stay silent about this. This is about more than my family or your families; it's about the future elections and the fundamental human right to participate safely in the democratic process.

CHAIR: Wow, Mr Daniel-Reid. Thank you very much for that powerful evidence. What you've just described is my worst nightmare as a parent in this role. I think what you've outlined is completely unacceptable behaviour. We've heard evidence of recommendations for codes of conduct. You're specifically calling for one for candidates. What would you propose or what thoughts have you had about enforceability of these codes of conduct? If they are signed or do become part of the process, how would they be enforced, and what penalties would apply if candidates, volunteers or supporters were to breach them?

Mr Daniel-Reid: I think that the point of the code of conduct isn't the penalties that come with it. I think the way I was thinking about it is just that the expectation is on paper. It's not just a moral responsibility of the candidate to get up and say, 'This was horrible.' I want there to be written stuff on paper that, when candidates go to the AEC and give their form—

CHAIR: When they lodge the nomination.

Mr Daniel-Reid: Yes. When they lodge their nomination, there should be a form that mandates for them to have these moral responsibilities that currently aren't written on paper.

CHAIR: Was some of the abuse that you've outlined in your evidence today that perpetrated by random members of the public, or were you able to specifically identify them as supporters of the Liberal candidate?

Mr Daniel-Reid: When I was leaving to go back to my car after the Brighton prepoll, that was someone in a Tim Wilson T-shirt.

CHAIR: So they were wearing T-shirts.

Mr Daniel-Reid: Some of the others—I can assume potentially.

CHAIR: Alright. I'm wary of time, so we'll—

Senator GROGAN: Can I just have a quick follow-up on that?

CHAIR: Yes.

Senator GROGAN: Thank you so much. It was really brave of you to come here today. What you've told us is really alarming and I'm really sorry for what you and your family have had to go through. To the issue of a code of conduct, one of the challenges that we sometimes see is around whether a person is a volunteer, is connected to another particular candidate or is it just a random member of the community. Do you have any ideas about how we can differentiate that so that we can look to deal with both of those groups? There is a broader community

thing, but the more that candidates allow their volunteers to behave like that, the more it makes it okay for everybody else to join in.

Mr Daniel-Reid: In this case, for the doxxing specifically—whether that's from a supporter or a work colleague of Tim Wilson—I think there should have been a mandate for him to come out and say, 'Look, this wasn't okay,' rather than asking my mum to apologise for making it up, essentially. I think that's an example of where it's actually not an issue of differentiating between supporters. The bottom line is that it's not okay. To come out and say, 'I condemn this completely whether the person was part of my team or not,' is the lowest expectation—and that wasn't met.

Senator GROGAN: So reinforcing the social norms, as it were.

Mr Daniel-Reid: Yes.

Senator GROGAN: Thank you very much for that, and send my regards to your mum.

Dr RYAN: Thanks Arkie. Do you have any other ideas about how we can keep safe any volunteer who's involved in the political process? I think it's an issue for people from parties—obviously for people who represent independents but also for people from parties as well. I think we've heard from lots of individuals in the last few weeks that volunteers are less likely to be involved in future campaigns because of their experiences in 2025. Do you have any other thoughts about that?

Mr Daniel-Reid: I think it starts at the top: candidates, parties, third parties. The use of really inflammatory and divisive politics, bad-faith politics used for political gain, is always going to end badly. And Australia is moving towards a more divisive political environment. We've seen what's happened in the United States, with Charlie Kirk assassinated, for example. People may think, 'Well, that's super extreme,' but it starts with me walking down the street and getting told some of the stuff I was told. When you allow that to continue, it will just continue to erode and erode until something unimaginable happens. I think we have a responsibility—you have a responsibility, as members of parliament and senators, to ensure that inflammatory political commentary isn't used for political gain. Otherwise, we'll continue to see Australia's democracy become more divided, and more subjective, than ever.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell.

Mr BURNELL: Thank you, Mr Daniel-Reid. You are an impressive young man and your mother would be extremely proud of you. I think I should put on the record that your mother was a very well respected colleague of ours in Canberra and made significant contributions to our democratic discourse. So all the best to her in the future. But to you: I assume, and I'm making an assumption here, so I may be made to look like an arse, that you participated on the 2022 campaign with your mother. I would be keen to get your take on what the 2022 experience was like compared to the 2025 experience, and on how much more aggressive the 2025 experience was.

Mr Daniel-Reid: You can't even compare the two. The 2022 election, while it had its moments, was nothing compared to this year.

I think the presence of third parties at polling booths was scary at times. It was invasive, and people walking to vote were mocked. Even the process in getting your spot at a prepoll booth—for the volunteers, we had to rock up super, super early in the morning to put our marquee up. The passion around it was edging on too much. In Goldstein particularly—it might be hard to understand in different electorates—it was a really big thing and super, super divisive. It just felt like it had a lot more hate and anger intertwined through this election than in 2022.

Mr BURNELL: Just expanding on that, you talked about third-party involvement. I'd be keen to get an indication as to whether you were able to identify what third parties were involved, but paint a picture. My electorate of Spence, in the northern suburbs of Adelaide, is very, I would consider, gentlemanly. There is a fairly good, jovial spirit on the prepoll and polling booths. It's a fairly orderly affair. I'm not sure what Goldstein was like, but I did see footage from across the country. I think it would be advantageous to get on the record what prepoll or polling day looked like for you.

Mr Daniel-Reid: We had Neo-Nazis rock up to Brighton prepoll. Driving down the Nepean Highway, there were third-party smear attacks on my mum. At the polling booths, Repeal the Teal, ADVANCE, Better Australia—we had a lot of people. I think some of the others are going to into depth about the third parties. It was an issue and it did contribute to toxic nature in which the 2025 election was held.

CHAIR: After what you've been through in 2022 and 2025, how likely are you to participate in the electoral process again? Please don't read into this whether or not your mum is going to run again. In terms you as a potential volunteer or someone engaged in politics, has 2025 had an impact on you participating in future.

Mr Daniel-Reid: Not at all. I'm not going to be intimidated by anyone in this country or in the world. I'll continue to fight for my mum, and I'll continue to fight for what I think is right. I'll just put on the record that it didn't work.

Senator GROGAN: Well done.

CHAIR: No, it didn't. Thanks, mate. We really appreciate your time. I now call Sue Barrett.

Susan Barrett: I'm representing hundreds of Team Zoe volunteers in the 2025 federal election in Goldstein. I've lived in Goldstein for 40 years. For most of my life, voting was benign, even pleasant. That changed dramatically when systemic intimidation, threats, doxxing and harassment became the defining feature of our electoral process. This didn't begin in 2025. It began in early 2022, when our grassroots movement threatened the political establishment.

In April 2022, front-page newspaper articles falsely accused our campaign team of antisemitism. The result: death threats, messages calling us 'Nazis', physical intimidation at street meets, swastikas on our signs, dog faeces in supporters' letterboxes. By late April, I requested Australian Federal Police and Victoria Police protection for a family friendly campaign event expecting 200 people including children. The AFP and Victoria Police told us that they had never seen this level of threat and harassment in any Australian election. That was 2022.

Then came 2025—exponentially worse. ADVANCE Australia, Repeal the Teal and other proxy groups spent $1.58 million on attack advertising in Goldstein alone, more than any other electorate in Australia. When the AFP briefed our staff in 2025, they repeated with greater alarm that they had never seen harassment like in Goldstein. They warned staff to park away from the office, to not wear campaign T-shirts and to move in groups of three or four for personal safety. One young woman said, 'I was spat at. Someone screamed I was a Nazi. I went home and cried. I am 23 and I just wanted to help my community.' At Cheltenham prepoll on 26 April, violent threats were made against the sitting member. When challenged, perpetrators turned on young female volunteers from other campaigns, abusing them until one fled in distress. The AEC issued a warning. The response: contemptuous laughter from Liberal Party volunteers. One of our volunteers wrote: 'I have had people inches from my face, screaming I am an antisemite, been followed to my car and—the worst part—nothing happened; they learned they could get away without consequences. We created the sunshine squad—volunteers ensuring safety at prepoll and polling booths. In Australia in 2025, we needed a security squad to protect our democratic participation.

Volunteers from various proxy groups supporting the Liberal candidate switched identifying materials at polling booths to evade AEC accountability while maintaining an intimidatory presence. Multiple proxy groups coordinated, flooding our electorate with attack advertising, loudspeaker disruption, coordinated group intimidation, doxxing and improper use of sensitive voter data to make calls on behalf of the Liberal Party. Days before the election, the Victorian Catholic Education Authority sent misleading letters to parents in Goldstein about school funding. The *Age* noted its chief of staff previously worked as chief of staff to the Liberal candidate. Inadequate enforcement created a permissive environment where even Neo-Nazis participated in this intimidation.

So what does this mean? Goldstein was a laboratory. Tactics tested in 2022, refined in 2023 and fully deployed in 2025 worked. Our member lost by just 175 votes. Even during the recount, our scrutineers faced ongoing intimidation. The playbook is written: without reform, what happened in Goldstein will spread to every marginal seat across Australia.

We have five requests for reform; first, ban third-party proxies at polling booths, with criminal penalties; second, mandatory real-time funding disclosure, because, when $1.58 mil attacks one candidate, voters deserve to know who is paying while voting, not six months later; third, truth-in-political-advertising laws with independent oversight and real penalties; fourth, exclusive AEC control of postal votes because statistical anomalies warrant serious investigation; and fifth, new anti-intimidation offences for emergency AEC enforcement powers. When young women are spat at and driven from booths in tears, when volunteers need AFP security briefings and protection squads and when requests to halt violent threats are met with contemptuous laughter and more intimidation, current laws have catastrophically failed.

My 40 years of benign voting have been replaced by an environment requiring police protection, security squads and AFP warnings. You can view this as isolated or recognise it as an existential threat to Australian democracy. We have provided the evidence, we have proposed the solutions, our volunteers have paid the price.

What happened in Goldstein is a warning. What happens next is a choice. The question is whether the committee has the courage to act before this destructive playbook becomes normalised across Australia.

CHAIR: Thank you, Ms Barrett. You mentioned that your scrutineers were intimidated as part of the recount process. Can you please expand on that a little bit more? What I'm trying to get to is this: was that inside the booth or as you were scrutineering? Was it outside or was it on the way in? Could you please unpack that for me.

Susan Barrett: I wasn't there personally. This is through information that has been gathered, and also provided in one of our submissions. There is also information that had been promoted on social media and in other areas that had identified there were plans, attempts and actions to intimidate our scrutineers. There will be other people who can speak about that.

CHAIR: Great. You mentioned penalties for misbehaviour or poor behaviour that you've outlined. I'd like to understand who you feel should be responsible for enforcing some of these rules. The AEC have given us pretty strong evidence that they don't want to be the regulator and the arbiter, so to speak. Who is best placed? We also think that ratcheting it up straight to the police is probably a step too far, so who should be responsible for identifying behaviour and then undertaking measures to stop that happening?

Susan Barrett: It's very tricky. Even when the Neo-Nazis turned up at prepoll, the police were called and they were there, but what they didn't want to do was escalate it even further so that Neo-Nazis could use us as propaganda to prop up their arguments. So we have a very difficult situation. If we ban all third-party groups from being anywhere near polling booths, that will actually help a lot with this issue that we're talking about here, so they're not even there to inflame the situation or carry out their intimidatory tactics towards us. That would actually remove a lot of the trouble that we have experienced, particularly at prepoll and polling booths. I'm not a legal person and so it's very hard, but the principles and the behaviour and, quite frankly, the level of moral disengagement that has been deployed by these proxy groups and their association with the Liberal Party has been deplorable. It is utterly contemptible.

CHAIR: Certainly I had similar experiences in Bennelong, and I share the same concerns as you that this behaviour becomes normalised. One last question from me for you and perhaps for other as they come up. The AEC has a pretty strict six-metre rule. They're responsible for everything within that and, by the evidence we have received so far, they don't really go outside the six metres. Was that the case down here in Goldstein? Would you recommend that that be reviewed for future elections?

Susan Barrett: It should be reviewed. Some of my colleagues, who will speak later, will talk specifically about that, but we do know that rule was flouted—not by us, but by others—and I think there need to be very clear lines, literally, to help manage that. One of the problems with the loudspeaker work—and that's when the AEC did come out—is that you could actually hear it inside the voting booth itself. The sound travelled, so the AEC came out for that.

We understand the AEC are not the AFP, right? They're not carrying guns and sorting out people, literally, from a violence perspective, but the problem is that we experienced not just the moral injury but physical intimidation. We were being spat at. We were having people bump into us. They were literally screaming in our faces like this. That is not normal behaviour. It should not be condoned and it should not be normalised. This is completely unacceptable.

I led the Voice campaign in 2023, and this was where we could see the warm-up event actually happening. My No. 1 priority for Goldstein, when I led that, was safety first. You could never do anything alone because we knew the physical threats and verbal threats coming our way, which they did, were real. And that just escalated in 2025. That's why I gave you the warm-up. This didn't just start happening in 2025; it started in 2022, for Goldstein at least. The Voice was an experimental laboratory for these proxy groups and others to see how far they could get away with the bad, terrible, destructive, violent behaviour that we experienced.

CHAIR: Thanks for your evidence.

Senator GROGAN: Thank you so much for being here today and for sharing your experiences. I couldn't agree with you more. It's a disgraceful way for our society to be heading. We have had a range of conversations with the AEC in terms of where their role begins and ends. One of the challenges they face is that a lot of the people who are working on the booths are employed by the AEC for six or eight weeks. So I can't see how it is going to work to turn them into enforcement humans at the same time. We need to find another way. Do you have any other ideas? There's no silver bullet here, right? As you say, we've seen it lift from 2022. Certainly, we had some hideous experiences at the referendum. The result of the referendum almost said that societal boundaries on being civil are now—the gloves are off. How do we pull that back? Do you have any other suggestions, apart

from not having any third parties there, about how we would ensure the management of those booths to keep our volunteers safe and our society as we would like it?

Susan Barrett: As I mentioned in my opening statement, for the last 40 years, voting in Goldstein was just walking up, putting in your vote and off you go. It was no big issue. But it has fundamentally changed, particularly in areas where the establishment has been challenged. Certain people don't like that, and they're very vocal, but they're not the majority. They are the minority. As I said, it doesn't matter what third party they are, if they're not allowed to be anywhere near polling booths at all—they just cannot be there—that will lower the temperature incredibly. I think that will restore and create a more stable environment for us. We can't expect AEC people—they're not security officers. So it is a very vexed question.

There's an old German saying: you sweep the staircase from the top. We need leadership on this. We need leadership from every MP and senator and also state and local members. We need to actually reset how we do politics and how we do democracy in this country and raise levels of civic education about what's acceptable and what's not. In Goldstein, for Team Zoe, we have our standards of behaviour and conduct. We encourage, train and develop people to be able to live by those. It is a standard operating procedure for us. Why can't it be for other parties? Why can't it be for other groups—that they have these standards for their volunteers?

I agree with Arkie; we need a code of conduct and standards. How we police that is the tricky bit. But if everyone knows what it is, then the majority can police it. The group can police it. Then people will feel comfortable and confident to say, 'That's not acceptable.' We all need to stand up as a democracy and as citizens. This is not acceptable. What happened is not acceptable. I'm pretty tough and strong, and, as Arkie said, I will absolutely keep turning up because I will not let these people win. They cannot take over and bully, intimidate and tyrannise us. We will not stand for it. We as a society have to stand up and actually hold them to account and make them realise that this is not on.

Senator GROGAN: One of my particular focal points is truth in political advertising. On this committee, we heard a lot of evidence in the last term about how we might go about something like that. Do you have any ideas about how to bring in truth in political advertising in a manner that would assist?

Susan Barrett: There are examples around the world. You just have to go to Germany. Why don't we just follow them, because they have truth in political advertising. They do not allow these sorts of things to actually be sent out. I think it's really important. There are precedents around the world.

Senator GROGAN: And in South Australia!

Susan Barrett: And in South Australia—apologies, Senator Grogan! But we have examples—

Senator GROGAN: We've had our laws since the eighties.

Susan Barrett: Yes. So this is really important that we actually make this a nation-wide mandate.

Senator GROGAN: Thank you so much. I really appreciate it.

Dr RYAN: I wonder if you could give us a little bit more information with regard to the reference you made to the integrity of the postal voting process.

Susan Barrett: In terms of postal voting—look at the distribution at the actual polling and the postal voting—there's quite a significant anomaly. Our concern is that postal votes are being sent out via parties. I have no idea what happens to that, but I'm concerned with the integrity of postal votes. It's not just me; we're concerned about the integrity of postal votes. That's why we are recommending that the AEC be in total control of that. Then, if anything is sent out to people, all of the how-to-vote cards or whatever there might be from whoever is standing in that seat are included so that the people who are receiving postal votes are actually able to make a fair assessment and not put one particular group inside postal votes. It's really important. We're worrying about the integrity of that.

Dr RYAN: Just to clarify, your suggestion would be that the postal vote applications aren't returned to political parties for processing and forwarding?

Susan Barrett: Not sent out by or returned to political parties—it goes via the AEC only. There are real issues that we're seeing for the integrity of that. Now, we don't have the authority or the power or the time or the ability to go and scrutinise that at depth, but, I think, if we stop it from happening in the future, then the integrity of postal voting would be more comforting for the rest of us who understand that we want to do democracy properly.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell.

Mr BURNELL: I've just got a quick one. Around polling booths, predominantly prepoll, do you think that having restrictions on the quantity of campaign material would greatly assist in de-escalating some of the conflict and nefarious intent that happens on polling days?

Susan Barrett: This is the challenge. In principle, yes, because it becomes a gauntlet that people have to walk down. However, if I speak on behalf of community Independents, we don't have the money or the firepower to be able to do the advertising that the big parties do. So we need to have some form of visibility at polling booths, prepoll, to be able to make sure that people are aware that we have a candidate. There's a real mix of how you make that work, but—

Mr BURNELL: If I put it to you though that, if we were to restrict each candidate to, say, two corflutes per entrance point, then everyone would be on a level playing field in the polling booth location. Outside of that, it's essentially up to each candidate to ensure that they run a campaign that elevates their profile to a level that they are recognisable at the polling booth, which we're all individually responsible for doing. Specifically around behavioural traits that are exacerbated at polling booths—I think, from my observations, predominantly during the prepoll process—if there were a limitation on booth material, in your view, would that help to de-escalate some of the scenarios that we've seen play out on the TVs?

Susan Barrett: Some of my colleagues will talk to that in more depth. I just think that we need something that's reasonable. Two might be too few, but, when you've got 32 for each, that's a bit much. What is the reasonable thing where people can actually have visibility, because capturing visibility and capturing share of mind is incredible important, as you know? That's why, when you've got groups and Independent candidates like we have and had, we are at a disadvantage when the big parties actually have much more firepower. How can we level the playing field so that we can make it fair, transparent and honourable?

CHAIR: Ms Campbell, you're online now. I'm sorry for not coming to you with the first witness. Do you have any questions?

Ms CAMPBELL: There's just one from me. Thank you very much for giving evidence before the committee today. You've talked about a number of third parties, including the Neo-Nazis, being present at the booths and the campaign that you were working on. I'm wondering whether you detected, saw, heard or had any evidence of coordination between those third parties?

Susan Barrett: Some of my colleagues who will speak later will go into more depth; however, as I mentioned in my opening remarks, we were able to identify and see that certain proxy groups had certain T-shirts on but would then switch out and change into a Liberal Party T shirt. If you want to call that a coordinated effort, I would say that's evidence of that.

Ms CAMPBELL: Which groups in particular did you see in that, as you said, coordinated effort?

Susan Barrett: The one that I can directly reference and my colleague speaking later can give you more information about was Repeal the Teal and the Liberal Party switching out T shirts.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much.

CHAIR: I have a final question, Ms Barrett. I just wanted to clarify. For those who register through the AEC, when the AEC sends out the ballot paper is it your recommendation that the AEC also send out how-to-votes or material for each candidate at that time? Is that what you're recommending?

Susan Barrett: Some of my colleagues will speak in more depth about that. Our No. 1 concern is that the AEC should be the only ones in charge of sending out and receiving postal vote information and votes. That's it. My colleagues will speak more to some of the things that you talk to. But, at bare minimum, the AEC should be the only ones that manage that.

CHAIR: Thank you for your attendance today. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, would you please forward it to the secretariat by Friday 28 November. I now welcome Professor Steve Selig. Do you have any comments to make on the capacity in which you appear before the committee?

Prof. Selig: I am a volunteer for the Independent candidate for Goldstein at the 2025 election.

CHAIR: I now invite you to deliver your five-minute statement before we proceed to questions.

Prof. Selig: Thank you. My name is Steve, and I'm 73. I've lived all of my life in Goldstein. I was a volunteer for the Independent candidate for Goldstein for both the 2022 and 2025 federal elections. Until 2022 I rarely felt that my vote counted in terms of having an MP who would represent my views and that of my family. I was overjoyed when I had the opportunity to vote for the Independent candidate for Goldstein for the 2022 election, and I decided to volunteer for that campaign. As a volunteer I was primarily a doorknocker, which made up more than 90 per cent of my volunteering for both elections. In 2022 after starting to doorknock very nervously, supported by very experienced volunteers, I came to love doorknocking because I got to meet with and listen to voters from all persuasions. Mostly these conversations were friendly and respectful, including voters who supported the Liberal candidate and sitting MP.

In 2025 I doorknocked six to seven days per week and knocked on about 2,500 properties. With a 40 per cent response rate, this meant that I personally talked to about 1,000 voters, which means that I have a significant sample size on which to draw on. In 2025 the tone of the campaign run by our opponent, his supporters and his volunteers changed dramatically for the worse. Whilst in 2022 the Liberal candidate thought that he would coast to victory without doing too much campaigning, this time he ran a campaign targeted directly at our candidate and dominated by lies, personal attacks and intimidation of our candidate and our volunteers. The Liberal candidate knew—and I assume tacitly approved—of some disgusting behaviour on the part of some of his volunteers and single-issue proxy groups, especially Repeal the Teal.

In contrast we signed up to a code of good conduct, and one of the proudest aspects of our campaign is that about 1,500 volunteers never wavered from behaving respectfully to all voters no matter who these voters were supporting. I am Jewish, so I felt the full fury and wrath of Jewish voters stirred up by the Liberal candidate, particularly those living in the north of the electorate. He weaponised, to his advantage, the issues of antisemitism, the war in Gaza, the State of Israel and the actions of the Israeli government and Hamas. The Liberal candidate needed to win almost all of the Jewish vote to win the election. He managed to conflate these issues so effectively as to portray our candidate as an antisemite in the eyes of many or most Jewish voters. The Independent candidate has justifiably been, at times, critical of the Israeli government, but this is no way makes her an antisemite. This was a lie but it won him the election.

I had a particularly nasty experience with a Liberal volunteer. I knocked on a door framed by a mezuzah in Caulfield South, and a man who was Jewish answered the door wearing a Liberal volunteer T-shirt. I was wearing my Independent T-Shirt. I said to him that, even though we were on opposing sides of the election, we could still be friendly, and I reached out my hand to offer a handshake. This was met with the man screaming abuse and profanities at my candidate and me, with threats for me to get off the property immediately. I felt rattled and depressed by this experience. This was just one example of many similar experiences. I felt equally rattled at prepolling, particularly at St Stephen's church in Brighton, where Repeal the Teal were behaving disgracefully.

Early in the campaign, I attended the In One Voice festival in Elsternwick, which showcases Jewish culture. For two hours I experienced the anger of members of the Jewish community, who stared at me or abused me for even being there in my campaign T-shirt. There were three exceptions to this: three people who declared support for the Liberal candidate but were open to having respectful discussions one on one with me. These three people helped sustain me in what was otherwise a very unpleasant experience. I got quite emotional with one of them, as we discovered that we were both descendants of Holocaust victims and survivors. The Independent candidate bravely attended this festival.

One of the most despicable strategies employed by the Liberal candidate in 2025 was to turn Jew against Jew and Jew against anyone who wasn't going to vote for him. I was yelled at, lectured to, emotionally and even physically intimidated by Jewish voters who, almost to a tee, declared that I should be ashamed of myself as a Jew supporting the Independent candidate.

Coming to my three recommendations: firstly, any individual group or group of individuals not representing a candidate for the election should be banned from campaigning at or near polling booths, including approaching voters and/or trying to distribute printed materials. Repeal the Teal operate as a proxy, undeclared and aggressive arm of the Liberal campaign and the candidate did nothing to stop this.

Secondly, truth in political advertising is badly needed and overdue to protect the integrity of future elections. Many of the billboards displayed along the Nepean Highway between Brighton and Moorabbin were based on lies and were disgusting to our candidate.

Finally, volunteers should be able to campaign without fear of, or actual, intimidation. Many of our volunteers felt too traumatised to continue to participate fully in the campaign. That certainly was my experience in the north of the electorate, where I had to stop campaigning. Of course, this applies to candidates, too. Our candidate was frequently subjected to disgusting abuse and intimidation and, at times, she felt very unsafe. Thank you for this opportunity to speak for you today.

CHAIR: Thanks for your evidence and for all your hard work in participating in our democracy. I'd like to ask some questions on that last point, regarding volunteers getting to a point where they no longer wanted to participate—and you made that decision, as well, which must have been a very difficult one to make. Could you outline the process by which you or other volunteers came to that decision? Was it towards the back end of a two-week prepoll? Did you just have enough of the intimidation on the booth? Talk me through it.

Prof. Selig: In 2022, I did a lot of doorknocking, though not as much as this time.

CHAIR: You did a lot—very impressive doorknocking, I've got to say.

Prof. Selig: I did a lot.

CHAIR: It's good.

Prof. Selig: My family asked me if I still live there!

CHAIR: It's good for the steps, isn't it?

Prof. Selig: In 2022 I did a lot of doorknocking. I was still feeling good enough to do prepolling. The prepolling wasn't as angry and horrible, and I did prepolling for about 40 hours. This time I got to about 10 hours of prepolling and I could no longer do any more.

CHAIR: Why was that?

Prof. Selig: I was broken down.

CHAIR: Sorry, mate.

Prof. Selig: I was broken. It happened in the north of the electorate.

CHAIR: How many prepoll booths were there in Goldstein?

Prof. Selig: Three. I think it was three, yes.

CHAIR: We can look that up.

Prof. Selig: I did about 10 hours altogether in Hampton and Brighton. Brighton was the worst; it was toxic.

CHAIR: Did you volunteer on election day?

Prof. Selig: Yes. I was scheduled to be at the polling station which was the most toxic, for the Jewish vote. I'm not saying that the Jews were toxic. The situation was toxic. Because of me and a few of my fellow Jews in the campaign—I couldn't do it. I had to contact one of our key members—leaders—to say that I just mentally couldn't do it. So I went to a very soft polling booth and I did about eight hours there.

CHAIR: Final question from me. Short of banning participation on polling booths, which I think may run into constitutional issues with the implied right of political freedom of expression, what steps do you feel could be taken by the AEC or a third-party body to remove the heat that, obviously, you and so many others experienced across the country? Is it the amount of people? Is it the content of what was said? Is it because the behaviour is being reported but not dealt with? What would have taken the heat out of prepoll in your advice?

Prof. Selig: In our electorate during the election, I don't think there was enough public shaming of the people who should have been publicly shamed. We've all signed up to Hansard today, and one of the things that I'd like to see is that the evidence that we give, whether it be refuted or not refuted and that we feel is truthful, is in the public domain. I think Sue talked about instant updates of money and so on. Instant updates of bad behaviour in the public domain would help a lot. I don't think there was enough public shaming of these people. One of the things that really got to me was that a lot of the Jewish people in the north part of the electorate felt entitled enough to behave disgracefully and still wanted everyone to love them unconditionally and side with them 100 per cent. They felt entitled enough to behave disgracefully. I never got that. That's not the Australia that I want. So I think public shaming.

CHAIR: Senator Grogan.

Senator GROGAN: Thank you for your evidence today, and I'm really sorry for the experience you had. Like you, I don't think that's the Australia that we know and love and wish to see flourish. On that role of public shaming, obviously there might be some issues with that. Have you thought, in any way, about a structural way of making sure that those behaviours are able to be identified? I don't know about here—maybe you could enlighten me—but in other places it was difficult to identify who that person was. They might have been wearing a shirt. They've said whatever they've said that aligned them with a third party or with a political candidate, but names weren't necessarily known. If somebody said something or did something, they'd sort of disappear off a booth and people would go, 'Oh, I don't know who that was,' or, 'They weren't with us.' There's that piece which we've heard a little bit about and that we certainly experienced in South Australia. Do you have a sense of how you might be able to structurally hold people to account if they are standing on a booth?

Prof. Selig: I've thought about this a bit. When you pull the shirt on or the cap on you have a duty of care at that time not to be attacking people with other shirts and other caps on. You have—

Senator GROGAN: How do we hold them to account?

Prof. Selig: I'd like to see more people in uniform in some, not all—St Stephens Anglican Church in Brighton has not got a bad enough record from 2022 and 2025. It was pretty bad in 2022, but it was so much worse this time. I'm talking more about prepolling; I wasn't there on polling day. The other problem is that there are three

prepolling stations, and there are about 37 polling stations on polling day, yet 50 per cent of people have already voted at three polling stations. It turns the heat up so much. If 50 to 60 per cent of people are going to do prepolling, then we need seven or eight prepolling booths and 20 polling booths on polling day. It's completely out of balance, and that's turned the heat up a lot, particularly in our electorate. Does that—

Senator GROGAN: Thank you.

CHAIR: That was what I was—prepolls funnel people in, and—

Prof. Selig: And the anger—

CHAIR: Yes, it goes up, particularly at day 11 of a two-week prepoll.

Dr RYAN: Thank you for your contribution. I'm sorry you had such a terribly difficult time with this campaign. I think we would all agree that the intrusion of religion into our political process in this country is to the process's detriment. How do we get it out? Obviously, this year was in some ways a little bit unique in terms of the tensions and distress that many separate communities were experiencing, but we're going to have similar sorts of things in the future again. Do you have any thoughts on how we do that? Obviously, Goldstein was a particularly problematic example, but it was an issue in many electorates around the country.

Prof. Selig: I've thought about that too. As you said, there was a concentration of around nine per cent of the electorate, something like that, so it's a big number. How do we get it out? A few of us were made to feel like we were antisemitic Jews. That's the feeling. It happened so much. It wasn't just once. How do we do that? I think we have to turn back to the Jewish community itself because they have to take some responsibility for some of the bad behaviour. I've never seen any recognition or acknowledgement at all. They celebrated the win in Goldstein, the way it was done. They celebrated it, and I'm pretty distressed about that. Our candidate tried to communicate over and over again with the Jewish community, but they had been successfully switched off. The Liberal candidate did a wonderful job in portraying her as an antisemite.

Dr RYAN: Do you think the third-party engagement made the issue of weaponisation of religious or cultural differences more challenging to deal with?

Prof. Selig: Yes. We went to the candidates meeting and debate in the Brighton synagogue. It could have been civil, but it ended up not being civil, and there were lots of T-shirts being handed out. I was sitting next to someone who was handing out T-shirts to anyone who would take a T-shirt—not our colour. They ended up being, we know, proxy Liberal—

Dr RYAN: 'Proxy Liberal'—are you able to say which group?

Prof. Selig: Repeal the Teal and, I think, Better Australia. Yellow T-shirts were handed out right next to me. The chairperson tried to say that this was going to be a respectful debate, and then it disintegrated very quickly. It wasn't respectful. There was ghastly billboard advertising on a truck outside.

Mr BURNELL: Steve, I'm sorry to hear about your experience. As someone who has been actively involved in campaigns for the best part of 20 years—I have fond memories of standing at a polling booth with my father when I was five and six years of age—that's not an experience that anyone wants to go through. I'm sorry to hear that. Fortunately for myself, I'm yet to experience that—and I hope I never do.

I think the chair alluded to the enforcement of behavioural standards earlier, but I just want to get some clarification. The AEC have indicated that they really need to pre-eminently have oversight of the execution of the election and making sure that the integrity of the vote is maintained. Would you be supportive of a third-party body taking care of all jurisdictional issues outside of the six-metre zone in the vicinity of the polling booths to have a level of oversight and enforcement of behavioural standards during the electoral process, be it the two-week prepoll and polling day process?

Prof. Selig: The short answer is yes.

Mr BURNELL: That's it from me, Chair.

CHAIR: Thank you, Steve. We really appreciate your time today. Steve, if you've been asked to provide any additional information, please forward it to the secretariat by 28 November.

I now call Jenny Chin and Tim Wade, who are appearing on behalf of Kerryn Rozenbergs, who wrote a submission—is that correct? That's the advice I've got. Is there anything you would like to add to the capacity in which you appear today?

Ms Chin: I am one of the co-authors of the submission to the committee.

CHAIR: Thanks for your time today. I invite you to deliver a joint statement, and then we can ask some questions.

Mr Wade: Thank you for giving us the opportunity to share our experiences in the recent election, and to listen to our ideas to make Australian democracy stronger. We appreciate you coming to Kew.

My colleagues and I are voices for a large group of Kooyong constituents. We're here today because we care about the state of our democracy. As volunteers during the campaign, we witnessed slurs, insults, harassment, hate speech and threats of violence, and we really fear that the 2025 elections might have crossed the line from a respectful competition of ideas to targeted aggression, intimidation and misinformation. A significant amount of that was from multiple third-parties rather than from the standing candidates and their campaigns. We know you have received submissions from all over the country voicing similar concerns.

The 2025 environment undermines the principle that a citizen should be able to exercise their political rights freely and without interference. It discourages civil society, including participation. To address this untenable situation, we would like all candidates and campaigners to adopt a new AEC designed code of conduct on acceptable behaviour during elections, with details on how bad behaviour will be addressed.

Safety became an issue during prepolling in Kooyong. Venues were unsuitable. In Kew, there was no room to accommodate the queuing voters and normal street traffic. There was excessive signage and overcrowding due to the popularity of early voting. There was no single authority to enforce existing rules about bad behaviour and safe areas for voters approaching polling booths. We need clear rules, enforced by the AEC, limiting the amount, type and location of signage for candidates and other campaigns at polling booths. Where there is the demand, there should be an appropriate increase in the number of prepolling centres. And, to improve the AEC's ability to plan ahead, to reduce costs associated with frequent elections and to enhance the governing of our country, we're in favour of four-year fixed terms.

Confusion extended to those voting by post and those who rely on mobile voting teams at care facilities. Aged-care residents did not always have access to the information they needed about how to vote and in some situations were encouraged to vote for particular candidates by aged-care staff. This is simply unacceptable and of particular concern given the vulnerability of this population. We recommend that the AEC publish guidelines for mobile voting, covering roles and responsibilities, and also re-examine the processes adopted for postal voting to stop data harvesting.

Campaign transparency has been a core concern of our group. We recommend tightening the rules regarding the registration of smaller third parties and requiring basic information about all third-party campaigns to be publicly available and easily accessible. Additionally, we recommend that the AEC create an icon to distinguish political parties or candidates from third parties. Truth-in-political-advertising laws should also be reconsidered. We call attention to the involvement of the Plymouth Brethren Christian Church in the Kooyong electorate and request a public inquiry into their activities during the 2025 election.

We strongly urge the committee to ensure that the AEC, which is the key institution overcoming many of the challenges to our democracy, is adequately resourced. To shore up our democratic foundations, we recommend civics education for all, including digital literacy.

Thank you again for your consideration of our submission. We welcome your questions.

CHAIR: Thank you. I just have a question about the Plymouth Brethren. Could you outline, I guess, some of the activities that you and your team witnessed with their involvement during the election campaign. When did it start? Where were they?

Ms Chin: They were definitely at the start of prepolling. I was there on the second day of prepolling in Kew, and they were there. They were prominent all the time, throughout prepolling. Within our submission, we have given many, many examples of their activities. Crowding around elderly voters, for example, is one of them. Within there, there are other examples of what they did. So they were active from the very start of prepolling.

CHAIR: Were they supporting a particular candidate, just for the record?

Ms Chin: They were wearing Liberal Party T-shirts, so far as we—yes.

CHAIR: Do you have any understanding of why they turned up for the Liberal candidate in such numbers?

Ms Chin: Apart from what has been reported in the media, various volunteers have had conversations with volunteers who said they were from the Brethren church and their entire families—siblings—were volunteering. They didn't really know what was going on, but they were told to be there.

CHAIR: So they were directed?

Ms Chin: They were directed.

CHAIR: They were directed to be there.

Mr Wade: And that's the concern. This is a group that has tax advantages. They're not supposed to be involved in political activities. This was an organised group. They came together. They talked together. They were wearing the same clothes.

CHAIR: And directed to be there?

Mr Wade: And directed to be there, yes.

CHAIR: And you saw that as a coordinated rollout, hand in glove with the Liberal candidate?

Ms Chin: Well, they were wearing Liberal Party T-shirts, and we knew that these volunteers were different from the normal Liberal Party volunteers that we saw in 2022. They were very young. A lot of them were very, very young, and they were there in quite extraordinary numbers.

CHAIR: Were you seeing the same people every day? Was it consistent throughout the prepoll period?

Mr Wade: Maybe not every day, but, yes. There are Liberal Party and Labor Party volunteers that I see at my school where I do my thing every election. This was a different group. They came in differently; they looked different. It was coordinated.

CHAIR: We've been asked to look at domestic and foreign interference into the election. We've heard evidence so far from the AFP, the AEC and others that foreign interference is pretty easy to define. With domestic interference it's a little bit more difficult because Australian citizens are allowed to participate in the electoral process. Given your experience of third-party involvement in the 2025 election, would you define some of that behaviour that we've heard of from yourselves but also from others today as interference in the election?

Mr Wade: That's a really tough question. I'm also a citizen of the United States, which has a bill of rights, which is a very different legal system from this country. I believe in the ability to participate in the political system. My concern was about confusion. There's a behaviour thing, which can be party supporters and third parties, but there's also a confusion thing.

CHAIR: That mis- and disinformation confusion, would you classify that as interference in the electoral process?

Mr Wade: I don't know if I'd call it interference, but we need to give voters some visual cues here. They would walk up to Better Australia, ADVANCE Australia people, at prepoll. They thought they were candidates or supporting a party: 'Which group are you?' So I think there are two slightly different issues. One is about behaviour of everybody—and with the third-party people we saw some really poor behaviour—but also it's about the confusion: 'Who are you from? What's your point?'

One of the things that really frustrated me was that the AEC supervisor in Malvern at the prepoll was wearing a yellow vest. It was really hard to tell the difference between them and Better Australia. The AEC should be in purple only. Purple is the magic colour. Again, I'm in marketing, so I'm always worried about the visual cues. There was confusion. They were confused about who were Repeal the Teal, who was Better Australia and who was ADVANCE Australia? We have a local environmental group here, Lighter Footprints. They're at every election, but they say who they are. People know who they are. They're the local environmental group, and they talk to members of parliament and council.

CHAIR: This was something else.

Mr Wade: This was something else.

CHAIR: Senator Grogan.

Senator GROGAN: I've got two issues. You talked about having a code, but you also referenced that code setting out what would happen if there was a breach of said code. What do you see as consequences of those breaches?

Mr Wade: The six-metre zone is wonderful, because the AEC supervisor can designate six metres from anywhere in the universe, and it's great because each physical location for a polling place is different. You guys must have been to hundreds of them, right? We've made an inner sanctum—great for us—and we've said, 'Beyond the six-metre line, it's—

CHAIR: The wild west—

Mr Wade: Yes. It's failed. It's totally failed. I really disagree with—do the AEC commissioner and the AFP commissioner go to every state and visit with the state police commissioners before every election? Did the supervisor at my school have a list of what was unacceptable behaviour? Had that supervisor met the local police person? I think we need somebody outside the six-metre zone. I don't think it's the AEC's job to police, but they could get guidelines that identify poor behaviour—it's standing over people; it's yelling. You can write down

guidelines. If that supervisor had a relationship with the local police, they could call them up. In researching this, I found out that an AEC supervisor can kick somebody off a polling place. Do they know that? What are the rules behind that? I think we can solve 80 per cent of the problems. I don't think it's that hard; I really don't.

Senator GROGAN: I think there are challenges there. I think one of the things that makes it easier is what you said about the four-year fixed terms. The challenge the AEC has at the moment, of course, is that they have to put an extraordinary amount of effort into having polling places available around the whole country for about 10 months because they don't know when the election is going to be. Then, when it comes down to the crunch, sometimes the ideal places are not available. I think the fixed four-year terms would do a lot to help us get better polling places. But the question I was really going to is: what are the consequences of the breach? In your statement earlier, you said that the code should include what the consequences of a breach should be. That's the piece I'm really wishing to tease out.

Mr Wade: At a polling place, it's evicting the person. They can do that. It is in the current law. I learnt that in preparing this thing. I was shocked. What are the rules? You warn them; you call the local policeman. He warns them and they're gone.

Senator GROGAN: In terms of a code of conduct, what would be the consequences for the candidate? Let's just go with the candidate, for example. Is the candidate responsible for their volunteers? Would any consequence be sheeted to the candidate or to the volunteers?

Mr Wade: I love the statement from Susan Barrett before about the staircase—that German one.

Senator GROGAN: Yes, I do too.

Mr Wade: It's setting a public standard. It's then going, for example, to Mr Laxale and saying, 'One of your volunteers broke the code of conduct,' and him saying, 'That won't happen again; that person got too emotional.' It's setting a standard. Will everyone meet the standard? No, but at least there will be a public standard. Even if it's not really enforced, there's something about setting a public standard and making the campaigns responsible for that standard and giving journalists something to refer to in that conversation.

Senator GROGAN: Not just behaviour but behaviour and a breach of a signed and agreed code.

Mr Wade: Yes.

Ms Chin: We as volunteers sign a code of conduct. I recall signing a code of conduct before I joined the volunteer group. Therefore, we have personal responsibility but not only that; we have responsibility to the campaign, and the campaign can say to us what or what not to do. That responsibility flows back to the campaign as well because we have a relationship about what, as an individual, I can and can't do. I would have thought that if we did have a code of conduct designed by the AEC, with the AEC and the candidates, the AEC could go back to the candidates and say, 'Hang on a minute; you guys are not following the code of conduct.' The AEC could also publicise what hasn't been followed or what has gone wrong.

Can I just add that I saw the AEC working really well in 2022 in a large prepolling centre. They decided at one stage that there were way too many posters. Whoever was in charge called all the parties together, or the persons who had put themselves forward as being in charge of the volunteers at that prepoll centre at Box Hill, and said, 'Look, everyone has got to reduce the number of corflutes to five for each candidate.' Everyone complied. So, as Tim has suggested, coordination between the AEC and the volunteer leaders is also very important. I'm not quite sure what you do with third parties. Maybe banning them, as previous participants have said, might be the way to go.

CHAIR: Another one?

Senator GROGAN: Is that alright? I don't want to hog the time. Civics education—we know from all of the statistics that civics education in this country has declined alarmingly. In the last term, this committee did an inquiry into it. The only state that has stepped up to the plate in some of that so far is South Australia, where—there is a theme—

CHAIR: South Australian senator likes South Australia! Who would have thought?

Senator GROGAN: Who'd have thunk it! Our state government has mandated civics education across a range of years and across a range of topics, and has invested heavily in providing greater education for teachers. One of the challenges we face across the country, and we heard this in that inquiry, is that teachers are afraid to teach civics. They are afraid of backlash from parents if they say one word that then gets translated, through their children, back to the parents as being in any way political. They feel like they don't have the structures and education to be able to do it, so we're investing to do that. We've all been talking for a few years now about the

challenge of the level of civic awareness across our society. I don't just mean politics and I don't just mean elections, it's broader, but it does have a significant impact. What are we doing?

Mr Wade: You get what you pay for. The federal government funds a lot of state activities.

Senator GROGAN: Yes, but we don't direct them.

Ms Chin: I'm sure it's possible for you to work with your state government colleagues—

Senator GROGAN: My state government colleagues are fine. We've done it. It's the rest of the country I'm worried about. But I mean more consistently. We are doing this in schools, but there is a broader piece about our broader community. We have a lot of people who come and live in Australia, become Australian citizens, from countries with very different political structures. How do we make sure that they are fully aware of their rights and the fact that, once upon a time, we did have an electoral system where election day was a bit more like a carnival than the wild West. We'd like to see it go back to that.

Ms Chin: I have some experience of this, as I participated with a community level group that had obtained a grant from the Scanlon Foundation to provide civics lessons to adult Australians who do not speak English well. There is great demand for that kind of education. Quite a lot of that education had to be translated into the languages spoken by these people who wanted it. But with the use of AI translation, that process is getting, how can we say, more efficient?

Yes, as Tim says, it requires funding, it requires a whole-of-government effort. State governments, federal governments—you are the federal government and I'm sure you have ways of leveraging your power with the state governments. That is something that you all understand. You have ways of persuading them to ensure that there is mandatory civics education, but it also requires a whole-of-government effort. We have institutions who do very good things, provide very good materials—for example, the Parliamentary Education Office, the Museum of Australian Democracy, SBS—and they can all be leveraged to provide this kind of education, particularly to the adults who don't speak English well.

Senator GROGAN: Thank you.

Dr RYAN: First of all, let me thank you both for your time. I've found it very hard to hear the evidence given this morning, and I feel like I have to apologise on behalf of myself and Zoe for the trauma that our volunteers have experienced, which is a very difficult place to be. What we want in democracy is to maximise people's engagement with the process, but what we're hearing today and what we've heard in other hearings doesn't really speak to a process which is entirely healthy in that we're driving people away. I'm not sure that many people who've listened to the testimony this morning or on other occasions would be thinking, 'Gosh, that sounds great; note to self: I must engage in that process a lot in 2028.' I guess that's one thing to note.

I'm trying to get to a question here. Is there anything that you can offer political candidates or incumbents in terms of advice from yourselves to us to help regulate the process better, other than a code of conduct?

Mr Wade: The most disturbing thing for me was prepoll at Monash. I was standing beside a young Greens volunteer. She couldn't have been 20. I was about to finish my long day, walk down to your office and go to another meeting, and two Liberal supporters walked past and said just the nastiest things within 30 seconds of each other. If it's me, I can kind of blow it off, but for her I felt really bad. It's because that's the level of political conversation that was going on, and you're all responsible for that. When the then leader of the opposition says that there's a party in Australia that's antisemitic, that is a level of language that we haven't heard in this country. We can't be doing that. Even if there is a party that I don't like, I can't call them Nazis or racists. I've got to say, 'Hey, they're more right wing than me, and I disagree with this.' That's where you're responsible. What hurt me most wasn't the behaviour of the volunteers. It was the behaviour of the punters. It was the behaviour of the voters this time. They heard what you said as a group—I know not you, Mon—and they felt emboldened. That was what was different in 2025.

Dr RYAN: Would it be fair to say that that failure of leadership extended to the attitudes that were expressed at times to volunteers and people engaged in the process who came from a non-English-speaking background?

Ms Chin: Yes. We did see some of that in Kooyong, for sure. I guess it's a whole-of-country effort to get it right, and I know it's really, really hard on the candidates—but we can't give up, can we? I think it's really a whole-of-society effort, and that means engaging everyone to move forward to a better place. I'm pretty sure—I hope, anyway—no-one in whatever political party or in whatever pressure group wants to see extreme or violent politics in this country. In a sense, we are believing in our own society.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell.

Mr BURNELL: Thank you both for providing evidence today. I want to get a bit more clarification around what your definition of a normal Liberal volunteer is. Sorry! Well, I think it's important to try and establish the baseline for a normal political volunteer versus some of the other third-party types that you're talking about.

Mr Wade: It's people who are members of the party, people who understand the policies, people who know who the local member is, people who say that we should be focusing money on this issue and not that issue, people who are engaged and people who have policy concerns that I sometimes agree with and maybe don't agree with.

Mr BURNELL: You can have a civilised conversation—

Mr Wade: Yes.

Mr BURNELL: on the polling booth.

Ms Chin: And, can I just say, I met many of these people in the 2022 campaign.

Mr BURNELL: So that's our definition of a normal Liberal volunteer. What separated them from the rest of the pile, who clearly did not fit in that definition?

Mr Wade: The Brethren volunteers—

Mr BURNELL: Was it exclusively the Brethren part of [inaudible]?

Mr Wade: In my experience, it was, yes. They couldn't have that conversation. They didn't understand that part about policy. They turned up as a group, they handed out their cards and they left as a group. They're just all the same.

Mr BURNELL: I've read in your submission that there was some behaviour around when vehicles would rock up with elderly people—the vehicle would get swamped. It's here on page 28: 'One of our volunteers described their behaviour at Malvern prepoll. They swarmed cars with elderly voters. As soon as the car stopped and before they could get out, they were there shoving how-to-vote cards in their faces and made a big song and dance about assisting them.' Was this a fairly regular occurrence?

Mr Wade: Yes, very regular. I didn't go to Kew; I was in Malvern. It was dangerous—it's right on Glenferrie Road. There was poor signage. I think the AEC should invest more in signage. Prepoll was so different because they're in different locations every election. People drive to them. On election day, most people walk, and they've been to that school or that church several times. Again, from a communication perspective, the queues for prepoll are not very good. They need big signs—what the hours are. We need to fund that because people are just confused. And then they almost get hit by cars. It was really dangerous.

Mr BURNELL: I think Senator Grogan touched on this before around fixed dates, and having a bit more assurance around when an election is going to be held will assist in having more suitable locations picked for prepoll.

I want to get your thoughts on the implementation beyond the six-metre zone. I'm very cautious about—one of the things that I find extremely good about our system is that the AEC is really held in high esteem as a body of very high integrity and has a sole purpose, essentially, of ensuring the integrity of the vote. If we start to allow them to engage in policing outside the six-metre zone, it creates an issue, in my view, where the AEC can then be brought into disrepute around being potentially persuaded by a certain political persuasion. I've read and heard in several submissions that the AEC needs to police, but, on that basis, do you think that it would be better to have a third-party enforcement agency responsible for any infractions outside of the six-metre zone?

Mr Wade: I think you're way overcomplicating this. You can't stand over a person. You can't yell at them. You can't follow them if don't want to talk to you. You see that a lot.

You focus on actual behaviours. If somebody from the AEC or maybe another group outside—you warn the campaigner. If they do it again, you get the police to warn the campaigner. If they do it again, they're off the site.

Mr BURNELL: But who does that? It really can't be the AEC.

Mr Wade: We need somebody outside the six-metre zone. I don't care who they're employed by. Most people will get the friendly warning—'Yes, sorry, I'm just really into it today'—and behave.

Mr BURNELL: In line with that, in your experience and research, are the infractions happening more at prepoll versus polling day, or is it across all polling booths regardless of whether it's prepoll or actual polling day?

Mr Wade: I've had have four wonderful election days since I started volunteering at Auburn Primary School. It's been great. I hear from other booth captains—there are 40-something polling places in Kooyong; we probably need fewer and don't need that many—that it happens at five or six. Prepoll is different because it's so

concentrated and there are so many people there. The issue is sort of the same. Really it's the same issue. Prepoll goes on so long that people just get tired by day 3 or day 4.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much for sharing your experiences with us today. Also thank you to Ms Rozenbergs for putting together her submission. I was just going to follow on from Mr Burnell's questions and some of the questions beforehand. You said that when it came to the Brethren volunteers that they were different. Can you explain how you knew they were different?

Mr Wade: They were all dressed the same. They engaged very—

Ms CAMPBELL: What do you mean they were dressed the same?

Mr Wade: Early on at prepoll the young women were in supporter T-shirts and skirts—all the same skirts, all the same colour. That was sort of talked about, and then the next day they came in jeans. It was weird. They didn't really interact with the other Liberal volunteers that much.

Ms CAMPBELL: In terms of how you knew they were from the Brethren, how did you become aware of that?

Mr Wade: I wasn't at early prepoll, but it was one of those things that you just saw on our Slack chat: 'Hey, who is this group? This is kind of strange.' Then it got into the press, and that's how I first heard about it.

Ms Chin: It was fairly obvious at Kew prepoll, where I was at anyway, that these were very, very young people; they were not the normal Liberal Party volunteers that you would see at polling stations. They were very, very young. So it felt unusual because, really, they should have been at school, it felt to me.

Ms CAMPBELL: They were school age? You thought they were school-age children?

Ms Chin: Yes.

Mr Wade: I've noticed really young volunteers, especially from Labor and the Greens, but they were geeks like me when I was 15, talking about policy and worried about climate change and all that other stuff. This was different.

Ms CAMPBELL: Me too! You thought they were school-age children. Were they there during the middle of the weekdays as well?

Ms Chin: Yes, it was a weekday when I saw them at the Kew prepoll. For the large part, the girls were silent and, actually, so were most of the boys, except for one.

Ms CAMPBELL: Earlier you said that you believe they were directed to be there. What led you to believe that they were directed and that they weren't there as a choice of their own interest?

Ms Chin: I certainly saw at Kew prepoll adults in Liberal Party T-shirts directing them and talking to them.

Mr Wade: They came together, they left together and they were all dressed the same. It just looked coordinated. It didn't look like, 'Oh, there's Bill from the Labor Party, who just got off the train with his red T-shirt.'

Ms CAMPBELL: Were they driven there? If they came together, they left together and there were a lot of them, were they driven there?

Ms Chin: Personally, I only encountered them when we arrived at the polling booth, so I do not know how they got there.

Mr Wade: I can't recall. Actually, they were driven there. I saw that on election day—a few people got out of a car. It just looked coordinated. It looked strange. They weren't part of the normal political volunteer group.

Ms CAMPBELL: Page 28 of the submission from Ms Rozenbergs talks about them being bussed in together. What did they say to voters? Was it the same thing? Was it different things?

Ms Chin: For the most part, most of the young volunteers I saw at prepoll said nothing—particularly the girls; they were very silent. A couple of the older boys said things like, 'Make Australia happy again.' Have I got that right?

Mr Wade: Yes. You guys must have spent a thousand hours on polling booths, and you're trying to engage with somebody. Even if you see them walk past with another team's hot-to-vote card, you smile at them and you say, 'Beautiful day today.' It was weird.

Ms CAMPBELL: My last question: when volunteers from your campaign were speaking to them or asked where they were from, what were the responses?

Mr Wade: I didn't really ask where they were from, but they didn't know anything about the policies. That was a real surprise.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much.

CHAIR: Thank you for your attendance here today. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, please forward it to the secretariat by Friday 28 November 2025. To all those who appeared this morning, we really appreciate your time and effort and really powerful evidence. Speaking on behalf of those here today and Ms Campbell online, I just want you to be very aware that we really share the same concerns you do about what is considered normal in terms of participation. I personally don't want to see 2025 repeated again, which is why I've made the decision to bring this committee out into the community to hear directly from those who were impacted. We know it wasn't the same everywhere, but it certainly happened way too much. I'd like to thank you for your resilience and your efforts to come out and put some really powerful evidence to the committee and into the *Hansard* so that we can make recommendations to the minister.

Proceedings suspended from 10:47 to 11:15

FORDYCE, Dr Robbie, Research Lead, RECapture

HEEMSBERGEN, Dr Luke, Research Lead, RECapture

YANG, Dr Fan, Research Lead, RECapture

CHAIR: Welcome. I now invite you to deliver a brief statement before we proceed to questions.

Dr Yang: Thank you very much for inviting us to this very important inquiry. The RECapture project started in 2019, and since then we have been studying the operation of Chinese language social media services in Australia. Via this kind of work, we have viewed one of the world's largest data sets of political communication content.

During the 2025 Australian federal election, we studied political disinformation and advertising on Chinese language social media services, and we actively provided data analysis to the AEC and fact-checking bodies to inform their understanding and immediate intervention. We have published our findings in leading international media outlets and academic journals by Harvard University, and our submission is based on this stream of work.

Australia faces both real and perceived disinformation challenges eroding public trust in elections. Today, we will focus on the importance of Chinese language social media services WeChat, RedNote and Chinese language channels on YouTube. These social media services represent emerging markets of surge, communication and e-commerce, with more than 70 per cent of Chinese Australians considering them as primary sources of news and information. Media accounts on these platforms mostly translate Australian news stories for their subscribers and followers. Advertisements in small businesses with large followings are not regulated or registered by their platforms, including political advertisements during the election.

In more research, we found disinformation is a systemic problem. A focus on individual acts of disinformation harm will always come too late, creating detection burdens for elections officials and are too intrusive on the communication rights of Australians. Instead, paying attention to disinformation patterns will inform effective design of intervention messages and strategies.

Emerging forms of political advertising shaped by platform functionalities together with the rising impact of AI impose new challenges for authorisation requirements. We have therefore offered some initial steps to help ensure integrity in future elections. A machine-readable layer for political authorisation to increase the efficiency of the AEC and its partners practices will improve confidence in election advertising. Greater transparency is needed in workflows of political advertising to address voter privacy concerns, and discourage clickbait economies that mislead political messaging. Applying ground up monitoring of non-English social media services to prebunk and debunk highly mobile, misleading narratives across platforms if needed as well, and these narratives are likely to gain audience very quickly and influence the way electors vote.

Despite our expectation to the contrary, we have not yet detected any nation state disinformation campaigns across China's language social media services in our research scope. Disinformation does occur, and it's mostly internal, through the Australian media market. This also means that a considerable designation of jurisdiction based disinformation regulation can help address the issue. As with all communications concerns, we embrace the balance to be met between the right to communicate freely and the right for all Australians to participate in free and fair elections.

Thank you once again for inviting RECapture today. We welcome any questions that you may have about our findings on WeChat, RedNote and Chinese language channels on YouTube.

CHAIR: Thank you, Dr Yang, for your statement and for your work on behalf of RECapture. As an MP with a very large Chinese Australian community, in Bennelong, I found it particularly important for me to understand what you're saying, and I think it's important for us all to deal with the systemic problem of disinformation that you're seeing, particularly on Chinese social media.

You mentioned in your opening statement that you provided analysis to the AEC of some of the disinformation that you detected. Could you please go through the process of how you detected that disinformation, how you reported it to the AEC, what their response was to you and what impact your reporting had.

Dr Yang: During the Australian election, we were supported by three research assistants coming from media communication studies, journalism and fact-checking backgrounds. We used a framework that has been used by AAP FactCheck in terms of categorising and detecting what disinformation is. This framework is shaped by the idea of truthfulness and falsehood of information and whether information is unproven or not. We followed that framework.

Every day my research assistant and I read content from WeChat and RedNote. If we identified, for example, a disinformation narrative, we would report the disinformation narrative to our intermediary platform so that we were aware of what was going on across these three platforms. Every week we would have a meeting. When my research assistant and I reported disinformation narratives, we would always provide a justification in terms of why we considered a piece of information to be misleading and what the source of information was—things like that.

From there we curated a dataset on our Google spreadsheet, and we shared this dataset with the AEC, AAP FactCheck and ABC News Verify. I am actually happy to show you what the dataset looks like. The RECapture team would provide a weekly newsletter for the AEC and AAP FactCheck in terms of what we had found, what kinds of disinformation narratives were surfacing on these platforms and what kinds of political advertisements the AEC needed to be concerned by.

That's what we do. Robbie and Luke might want to contribute.

Dr Heemsbergen: I'll just add that I think that weekly newsletter to the fact-checking organisations was actually at their request. We were sending them original pieces of disinformation when we got them or when we could. They were thankful for that and said, 'If you could regularise this in some way so that we can action it at a time, that would be useful.' So we shifted our internal process with our own technology so we could do that for them.

I think Fan can even maybe speak more to the end of your question about what actions were taken. We saw numerous pieces in the media that appeared because of our work, and I believe the AEC actually moved on some of those pieces as well, but you might want to speak to them more on that.

Dr Fordyce: I'd just add that the spreadsheet was updated as we identified disinformation, and it was live with the partners that we were sharing it with, so there was never really any kind of delay in terms of, for example, a week-long period. They would have that information available to them as soon as we did as well.

CHAIR: How did you detect it? Did you have software or algorithms going through and picking up things that were electoral matters, was it your three research assistants literally doomscrolling, or was it people reporting things to you? You talk about early detection. How did you manage to sift through those platforms?

Dr Yang: Just to respond to the automation aspect, that is actually one future direction approach. Luke will speak a little bit more after this. As to our detection approach during the election, we were all coming from professional media and journalism fact-checking backgrounds, and three research assistants and I are bilingual researchers. So, on the one hand, we consume stories from Australian official information and also news stories published by the *Guardian*, the ABC and SBS, which we consider to be legitimate news sources. On the other hand, we also read news information from WeChat and RedNote. When you consume information from multiple sources and when you draw the comparison, disinformation is very obvious. It's very apparent. We know this information is exaggerating the possibility of the event.

Based on our detection work, we were able to summarise disinformation strategies that were used across those media outlets, which was really helpful for us to further detect disinformation narratives in a very effective way. Those disinformation strategies involved manipulating knowledge gaps, for example, if something is unknown—if something is unproven—it is very likely that that piece of information will be manipulated for public fear and anxiety. The second one is denying human rights, reinforcing existing social hierarchies, manipulating the possibility of certain events and reconfiguring speciality and temporality of existing events.

Another thing that we have identified that furthers disinformation narratives is that they don't have to make sense. When we read a piece or a story, the headline tells one thing, the text tells another thing and the image tells another thing. These elements all together didn't make sense, but the whole point of disinformation is not that it has to make sense. It doesn't have to be logical. It's that that information strikes fear and anxiety around the community members. That being said, sentiment, fear and anxiety is another standard that we use to detect disinformation at the stage when its being done all by humans.

CHAIR: You mentioned just then disinformation strategies. Your research is showing that this was a deliberate campaign of disinformation. Is that a correct statement, or was it haphazard? Were randoms doing it? Who was doing this?

Dr Heemsbergen: It's interesting. Speaking to what Fan just said around the fear and the anxiety, the way WeChat is structured with official accounts almost works like news magazines. So it doesn't have the spreadability or the virality of something on TikTok that can just go and go and go. You, as a consumer, sign up to three different accounts and you get your news from them. This news is translated from English news sources

and then given to you. Each of these official accounts—and I'm talking about the ones that deliver news—is set up almost like a small business. So they really are like SMEs that have their own bottom line.

They sell news to audiences. To sell news to audiences, the more catastrophe, the more fear and the more exclamation marks you can put after your headline, the bigger the audience you get. This isn't a new concept, but we see it happening on this platform for this audience. I say that because when we say, 'Is this a strategy?'—it's not a nation state strategy to turn the Australian election, on the whole. Most of what we saw wasn't a strategy by political actors in Australia to turn the election; it was an effect of a market looking to turn eyeballs. So, yes, it's a strategy, but it's not a political one. There are people on the internet who make money from the internet and don't care about our politics. That's what we saw happening here. At the same time, we did see Australian domestic actors that were using that space because it is—I don't want to say less regulated, but there's less visibility to the regulations that we do have in that space that you can take advantage of if you are a domestic actor with a political message.

Dr Yang: To add to that, effective communication and distribution of disinformation are, indeed, circulated to certain demographics. Therefore, there's a lack of visibility in their ads, because this information can be prioritised by platform algorithms and disinformation can be more effectively distributed when it's shared by a close social network because your social network lends another layer of credibility and trust to that information, whether that is misleading or not.

We also have some data in terms of who are the people involved in distributing disinformation. As Luke said, on WeChat, our focus is on small to medium-sized Chinese language media outlets operating in Australia but on RedNote it's a little bit different. We found that, both on WeChat and RedNote, immigration is a central topic when it comes to disinformation. This immigration topic involves visa policy changes, humanitarian immigration programs and pathways to Australian citizenship. Actors, be they organisations or individuals, who share this form of disinformation, such as commercial immigration education agencies, are monetising the anxiety, fear and even joy and excitement that they themselves hype up for further business deals. That's what we found. Maybe Robbie wants to add to that.

Dr Fordyce: I think what I would primarily add to this is that, given the nature of WeChat, RedNote and the other platforms that we've been looking at, each platform is different, and each has its own internal cultures, operations and business logic within them. They're all unique, but they also grant insights into kinds of behaviours that are probably taking place on other platforms, including English-language platforms. A lot of the stuff that, for instance, Luke has been describing isn't wholly different from the way that some influencers behave around other forms of disinformation that are not political, such as medical misinformation. We think the problem of inaccurate, misleading or deceptive information online is across a lot of sectors. It's just that we happen to be looking at this fairly tightly bound situation, where we have a unique advantage in terms of gathering data on it.

CHAIR: You said that—correct me if I'm wrong—you reported some of the disinformation you'd found to the platforms. Is that right? No?

Dr Fordyce: I don't think so.

Dr Yang: We didn't. But I think there were further consequential steps taken by either the AAP, ABC News Verify or the AEC in terms of requesting to take it down. But—

CHAIR: So you're saying they requested to take it down?

Dr Yang: They might have, but, within our capacity—

CHAIR: You didn't.

Dr Yang: No, we didn't.

CHAIR: Alright.

Dr Fordyce: It would probably be inappropriate for us to be doing that—

CHAIR: That's what I understood from the evidence of Dr Yang. If that's the case, that's fine. I just wanted to ask some questions about that, but it's okay if you didn't.

Senator GROGAN: Sorry; just to be clear, you did report those incidents to the platform?

Dr Yang: No.

Senator GROGAN: Okay. I misunderstood.

CHAIR: So did I. This is the final question from me before I go on to Senator Grogan. You've identified the impact of mis- and disinformation on the electoral process, and you've also identified that you didn't see any evidence of foreign interference. We've been asked to look at reforms around domestic interference into the

electoral process. I just want to understand, from your research and from what you've seen over the years since 2019: would you consider these campaigns of disinformation, where they're structured and deliberate—strategic disinformation campaigns—as electoral interference?

Dr Fordyce: It's a bit hard for us to make that call—whether something is a strategic attempt to undermine or intervene in the election process itself. We do see information that could potentially pervert the course of an election, and the AEC has recognised things that we've given them such that they've been able to remediate or prevent those perversions from taking place.

CHAIR: The AEC often step in when it's disinformation or incorrect information about the electoral process. I guess what I'm trying to understand is whether disinformation or misrepresentation of a candidate or of a policy position has the same impact as disinformation about the electoral process, from your research.

Dr Yang: From a statistical point of view, in terms of misleading information regarding the electoral process itself, we identified it was five per cent of them. Misleading information relating to the electoral process itself was not a big part of the disinformation narrative that we have identified. We have instead identified disinformation in the misrepresentation of particular policies and particular candidates, and, yes, we actually consider that.

Disinformation in relation to the election itself only occurs during the election. But we also see disinformation as an enduring, ongoing media phenomenon in the sense that there's a media ecology nurtured by WeChat, RedNote or YouTube, or maybe Instagram or TikTok—we can list many. This media ecology is nurturing and fostering disinformation, an effective information ecology that stirs up anxieties and fear towards policies around China's migrant communities here. Immigration is a really big part. The misrepresentation of immigration policies and of political candidates or politicians that discuss immigration policies has been an ongoing phenomenon. We're saying that the consequence is more significant than election-specific disinformation during election time, because, during a time of political tension or a political event, for example, or a health or climate crisis, that disinformation still exists and it just gets amplified even more. Maybe, Luke, you want to add more.

Dr Heemsbergen: The seeding of those narratives over time, between now and the next federal election, matters because it sets a the culture and understanding of whatever type of policy we're talking about—whether it be immigration and which party thinks what about policies that exist at present—so people go into the next election with those presumptions, even if they are incorrect.

To bring it back to how Fan ended our initial statement, we do recognise and embrace this balance between the right to communicate frequently and the right of Australians to participate in free and fair elections. With my political science background hat on, I see something sacrosanct around the elections, as opposed to what political advertising says about other politicians. That's a personal opinion from my training. And please don't take this the wrong way, but, if you come from the assumption that any kind of political advertising is in fact going to be somewhat untrue because it's an advertisement—it's not information; you're actually advertising a future outcome that you hope will happen—you see all of a sudden that there's a large grey area where you can say your own advertisements are disinformation. Again, please don't take that the wrong way. It's just logically thinking about it. If we think about what a political advertisement is, it's a promise that statistically is hard to keep.

That just shows the grey area that we do acknowledge, and how hard it is to think about a legislative response to this. We have the bill that has stalled—or ended now, I think, from last year. I think it was really interesting and really important to think about the community led and community based understandings of how we can break some of these disinformation cycles not just at election time but throughout so that there are integrations that are happening for people who get their news from sources that are not in English so they understand that what they're seeing and how they're seeing what they're seeing is skewed.

CHAIR: This is the last question from me. Where political disinformation has been identified, either in the course of an election or in between, what treatment would you recommend be applied to that and by whom?

Dr Yang: Our work is ongoing. We are still identifying disinformation in relation to Australian policies on WeChat. We have decided that civic education is very important. We have been developing a social curriculum for media literacy training for Chinese migrant communities. We publish in English, but how can we get our research to our communities? How can we communicate: 'Hey, this is the Chinese language media ecology here in Australia, this is how those commercially driven media outlets work every day, and this is how they produce and translate news stories. Guess what is missing? Fact checking.' We wanted this form of academic knowledge to get into the mindset of our community members, and we wanted to provide this very informed civic education system for our community members. This is the kind of work that we have been doing.

I think it is also very important for us to continue our collaboration with ABC News Verify and AAP FactCheck. One of the examples that we identified in the process of our disinformation detection was that we

identified a disinformation narrative in November last year, then that narrative repeated in March this year, and AAP FactCheck debunked that information in May or June this year. So the harm has already been caused and we have already reported this disinformation narrative, but fact checkers have very limited scope because of the political economy of how fact checking works in Australia, based on the partnership between major platforms. And they have very limited scope in terms of what platforms they are concerned with, and Chinese language social media services are outside their scope, unfortunately.

Dr Fordyce: There are probably two things I would note. Firstly—you can read our submission in terms of the detail—the machine-readable layer in political advertising, I think, is actually pretty important as a way of tracing the origin of advertising and ensuring that it is appropriately authorised so that both Australian citizens and the AEC, as well as researchers like us, can be involved in tracking and tracing political ads as they move across the system. I think that would be important for helping to determine what kind of content is coming from some sort of official capacity and what content is being created in an ad hoc manner. An escrow database with digitally signed systems could be managed by something like the AEC to coordinate this, and I think that would potentially be effective.

I also think that Australia is somewhat uniquely brave about the regulation of social media companies relative to other countries around the world. I think that bravery could go forward with things like trying to actually hold some of these platforms to account a bit more about their failures in transparency, which are frankly insufficient, as you might have already heard from other participants in the inquiry.

CHAIR: Senator Grogan.

Senator GROGAN: At the risk of labouring a couple of points here—I'm conscious you're coming very much from a research background; this inquiry has very much a political lens to it. You've spoken about a number of these platforms being SMEs and therefore having a bottom-line interest but also said that you don't think there's an overt political campaign running across this disinformation and misinformation that you're seeing. Is it just random bad actors, or do you have any sense of whether the disinformation that's coming through will tick up in trying to promote fear and anxiety? Do you have any sense of where that's coming from—as to either motivation or category?

Dr Fordyce: Just to be clear, this is what we see in terms of our detection. We have not seen any foreign interference that we would be able to identify within the system. In terms of the bad actors that we see, I'd be loath to consider this random in the sense that I don't think anyone here is stochastically engaged in typing random words into the internet and expecting something to happen out of it. Rather, as Luke says, there's a degree of clickbait logic to the SMEs that are operating on these platforms. I think, to some extent, what happens with the content as it moves from platform to platform through translation and through individual authors is that different errors get highlighted, and so, to an extent, some of the disinformation is a product of the media system as a whole, not exclusive to these platforms themselves. Did anyone else have anything to add?

Dr Heemsbergen: I don't think we're in a position to say that the absence of evidence is in fact evidence of absence. We don't want to go there, so we're stopped from making those nation-state claims or otherwise. I think that what Robbie has noted around the incentives that do exist, the extent to which they affect and impact communities in relation to Australian democracy, is like an externality to the economic loop that's happening there. In that space, that can be exploited, and it is, but do we see an overarching use of this space to do that? I would say no. Interestingly, as on WeChat, there was a formatting change to how users could interact. Videos came into the fore. Before, it was just text—these news magazines that you read—and then videos appeared. Very preliminary research suggests that something else is happening—something orchestrated might be happening in user comments to those videos, because that is something that is scalable through AI or other means. So that's very preliminary, and we want to look into that more, but the engagement with news content so far and with regard to the 2025 election didn't have those patterns.

Dr Yang: Those Chinese language media services on WeChat make money by attracting attention. This is how they sell their space. Maybe we could say it's how they lease their space. They provide their clients with their statistics: 'This is how many ratings we have achieved. This is how many articles have received more than 100,000 clicks.' The more subscribers they have, the more clicks that they have, the higher they can lease out their space for to advertisers. To some extent, on that point, political disinformation or disinformation in general works hand in hand with political advertisement. Based on one work, we have not yet seen the partisan orientation of particular media outlets here, but they're very inclusive. They're very open to political advertisers because they pay high. The payment is high. It's higher than a local restaurant. To that extent, we have often seen and often see that political advertisement is always placed with misleading news stories because they want to attract that attention, and then they can provide these statistics to their clients by saying, 'We have achieved this amount of

readers for you.' So this is an ecology—a kind of platform ecology that nurtures this problem of disinformation and political advertising attached to disinformation.

Senator GROGAN: Your comment earlier that the text, the headline and whatever graphic or photo may not actually be connected very well is not new. There is a grab headline, but then you read the story, and, if you're looking at it from an analytical perspective, you go, 'There's nothing in that story that would lead you to that headline.' But the headline is the one that goes, 'Oh my god!' On that basis, I'll come to your point about all political comms being a little bit—

Dr Heemsbergen: Inspirational.

Senator GROGAN: inspirational—yes, good word. Thank you. There's a debate about the difference between fact and opinion. When you're looking at truth in political advertising, there's a cold, hard fact delivered in an unemotional, unopinionated fashion. 'The sky is blue today.' Then the interpretation is: 'Yes, the sky is blue. We all understand that.' 'The sky is blue, but I think tomorrow it's going to be really cloudy,' is then an opinion. It's not a fact; it's an opinion. Then somebody else might say, 'Uh-huh, the sky is blue today, but tomorrow the sun is going to shine.' Again, it's an opinion. If you take that as a fact, that it's blue sky today—you stand outside, you look at it and it's blue—the interpretation that people then take from that is often what a political situation might look like. So if the economy looks like X today, political party A thinks it it's going to look like B tomorrow, and political party B thinks it's going to look like C tomorrow.

It's a debate that rages a little bit in South Australia, because we do have truth in political advertising. The truth in political advertising laws we have are what you would call light touch, but they work—probably because they've been around since the eighties and the penalties are intense for a political party under a capped system. Facts versus opinions—where is the line? How do you unpack that?

Dr Heemsbergen: It matters.

Dr Yang: In a more recently published article, we did have this question, in terms of the line between opinion and information. In our approach we followed work from an American political communication. They didn't really make a distinction, in terms of opinion and information. In our work, we didn't take that as a strict distinction, as a matter of fact. When it's on WeChat, when information is being broadcast, the whole point of those stories published by China's language media outlets—they don't even call it news journalism. They call themselves platforms—Facebook and Instagram call themselves that as well—and say, 'We're inclusive not in terms of opinion but because we want to present those different sides of information or opinions to attract advertisers, because advertisers would not want to see the truth. They would want to see how a particular article attracts different demographics or audiences.

Dr Heemsbergen: It's a very hard question. What I observe is that there are different consequences to having opinions in different fields. In Dr Ryan's practice, if her opinion were wrong and the outcomes were bad—that would never happen.

Dr RYAN: That would never happen!

Dr Heemsbergen: There would be consequences for that. We have seen reporting in the *Age* recently of homebirths influenced by people who have opinions. There are fewer consequences when their opinions of the sky being sunny during labour are incorrect. So I think, putting my academic hat back on, it's a really tough question. And, because it's a really tough question, society says that when you have these kinds of opinions, and consequences through your opinions, we have these kinds of incentives to keep you truthful, whether that be the southern Australian example or the various layers doctors exist under in terms of the regulations.

When we have other markets, for lack of a better term, like journalists on WeChat—Dr Yang's previous work looked at how the Australians who work in these SMEs on WeChat think of themselves as journalists but cannot get accredited as such. So they will be at a news site trying to do the job of journalists and will be turned away because they don't have the right accreditation. How do you get it? There are not allowed because—and we can go there. But society has decided that this group of actions is not journalism. Therefore, the consequences to the opinions there are in a different set. That hinders Australians who speak Chinese from engaging in our system in a way that I think they should.

Dr Yang: We also have this argument in Crikey's article in terms of whether we have an opinion or not. What is an opinion? Do we really have an opinion, or does opinion come from societal constructions of itself? When we try to distinguish the idea of journalistic facts and, for example, the use of opinion—when we produce news stories there is always a gatekeeping mechanism. Journalists do not produce stories for themselves. They are under editorialisation. The editors' editorialisation is shaped by the institutional agenda, and the institutional agenda is shaped by funding and partnerships—things like that. But, when it comes to personal opinion, it's like

there is a lack of a gatekeeping mechanism. But sometimes we do know that it's probably not the right place to say these kinds of things. I guess that's one of the distinctions we can make, but we should also think about where opinions come from and what are the factors that shape those opinions. Robbie?

Dr Fordyce: I don't really have that much to add to what the others have said, other than some of the questions that we're going to be asking about this in the future are going to be significantly shaped by the technology, like artificial intelligence, where the idea of an opinion as being something attached to a particular individual's thoughts are going to be deeply conflicted and confusing when we're no longer able to attribute a statement to an actual individual. I'll leave it at that.

Senator GROGAN: I could keep going for hours, but I'm conscious that I'm hogging the time. Chair, I'll hand back to you.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan.

Dr RYAN: Thank you very much. This is fascinating. I'm interested in that grey space of influencers and when someone who doesn't purport to be a political journalist posts content that has a political slant in some respect. What are your thoughts regarding the extent to which that should be labelled as political content or perhaps to what extent that should be regulated?

Dr Yang: That is what we have observed on RedNote. There is a blurred line between politically promotional content compared with political advertisement. It will be further blurred with the visually oriented platform being a very significant part of Australian political advertisements and campaigns.

Yes, we have indeed found instances where platform users post content on behalf of a political candidate, and this is because of RedNote's shadowban mechanism. A shadowban mechanism algorithm does not encourage any content involving policies. The algorithm also doesn't prioritise a political figure's profile. For example, if I want to search for you on RedNote or Douyin, I wouldn't be able to find your profile.

CHAIR: I was shadowbanned.

Dr Yang: Yes, shadowbanned, but, occasionally, maybe I will find your profile. If I clicked 'subscribe' then I will see your profile, but I would barely see your content on the main page, which is like the 'for you' page on TikTok.

Political candidates during the election found, for example, individual content creators, Chinese language small businesses, immigration businesses [inaudible] business, and they do podcasts with those content creators, and those content creators come with traffic. They come with big followings and with big subscription bases, and they play a very significant role in promoting those political figures and their campaigns, but that content is not labelled as political advertisement. That's why we also pointed out that the current status of political advertising in Australia posed a challenge for the AEC around current authorisation regulation.

Dr Fordyce: As academics, we do have the liberty of being able to step away from specific regulatory focus on individuals. For us, the question of disinformation is always a scalar systemic issue, and much less focused on individual influencers. Because our perspective is about the scale of this issue, we kind of see any individual influencer having any attention or presence on a platform as a product of business models of those platforms that essentially support and engender the presence of influencers on things like increasing their monthly active users, among other things. So the problem with influencers, at least to my mind, isn't about individual acts of communication that they make that might be misleading so much as the incentives that make this misleading content profitable for both the influencer and the platform as a whole.

Dr Heemsbergen: I might add to that. I think it's incumbent on the political campaigns for that transparency—which influencer they're paying what money to—rather than the influencer managing that. The reason I would go that way is that I think there's something really valuable about integrating new voices into our political processes. People are not getting their news where they used to, et cetera, and civic engagement via influencers—I don't think we should think of that as a bad thing, on its face. When a political candidate or a political organisation enables that, I would like to know. I think asking the influencer to do that is tough regulatorily, in terms of the practicality of it, and I think we already have systems set up that would be much easier to measure on the political organisation side. Putting it to the South Australian example, if you could have those kinds of incentives—negative incentives—to not do so, that would probably work pretty well when some influencer comes out and says, 'I got paid $10,000.'

Dr Yang: It's like the question of who should take the responsibility and accountability, right? When it comes to Chinese language social media services, especially for some political candidates who have very limited knowledge about what Chinese language social media services look like, they might just outsource or do subcontracting. Instead of managing the political campaign on Chinese language social media services

themselves, or by their teams, they would outsource the work to third-party contractors based in Australia. That is the starting point for the campaigning process getting out of their oversight, and then the third party may further subcontract their campaigning program or schemes to another party, whether based in Australia or based in China. We indeed found instances where two political candidates had Chinese celebrities endorse them on Douyin, which is the Chinese version of Tik Tok. When the celebrities got interviewed, they said: 'I have no idea who this person is. I was paid to do the work.' Hopefully this is visible and operational. We require greater transparency being provided in terms of understanding the political communication process—how the political campaign has been managed, what third-party actors/organisations were involved and what the spending on that was.

Dr RYAN: You mentioned that you didn't find any evidence of foreign influence in this election campaign. Did you find any evidence of political parties deliberately trying to create formal relationships or informal networks within the Chinese Australian community?

Dr Yang: Are we talking about political parties or candidates?

Dr RYAN: Either.

Dr Yang: For candidates, yes.

Dr RYAN: Candidates from parties?

Dr Yang: Candidates from parties or Independent candidates, yes.

Dr RYAN: Are you able to expand on that at all?

Dr Yang: I can expand on that. One of the profiles that we found was from Independent candidate Andy Yin. I think he is from Sydney—Strathfield?

CHAIR: Bradfield.

Dr Yang: He started his campaign very early on RedNote, and he didn't position himself as a political candidate at the time; he positioned himself as a kind of influencer. He went on the street fist bumping with passers-by, and he attracted lots of attention. His profile was the one that gained the highest amount of attention, with the largest volume of followers and subscribers on RedNote. He and another person, Scott Yung—they come from a Chinese language background, and they know very well how RedNote works. Offline they are able to accumulate community support in their ways, and online they collaborate with content producers and businesses. They engage with businesses, podcasters and content creators for their campaign, so yes.

Dr RYAN: That's interesting. If we unwrap that a little bit, the issue there is not that these individuals are undertaking these activities; it's that these individuals undertook these activities without being labelled or identified as political candidates—is that fair to say? Presumably, if they had been labelled as political candidates, that would have been picked up by a platform like RedNote?

Dr Heemsbergen: Yes. I think you probably still won't be able to find their profile if you use the search function, but you could try.

CHAIR: But they were posted on other people's profiles, right?

Dr Heemsbergen: Yes.

CHAIR: So the influencers would post about—

Dr Heemsbergen: Influencers already have a large number of followers, so they come with traffic and attention. Then, these people help or support candidates by promoting their campaign. We understand that content as political promotions. Even in our analysis we've labelled that as political promotion, because we're not sure whether that is political advertisement or not. By law, it is probably not because it is not authorised and is not from a political party or a candidate.

Dr RYAN: But it's a grey area, isn't it?

Dr Heemsbergen: It's a grey area.

Dr RYAN: Because that activity is presumably politically motivated.

Dr Heemsbergen: Yes, and you will see that users have debates in the comments by saying, 'Are you being paid to post this content?' And then they will deny that or they will refuse to respond. That is a side that is outside the word-search scope.

Dr RYAN: Interesting. Thank you very much.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell.

Mr BURNELL: Thank you for providing evidence today. A lot of this goes over my head. As my wife would probably attest, I'm digitally illiterate.

CHAIR: You're not on RedNote?

Mr BURNELL: No. I think that it's a good place to start: we can talk about regulation or we can talk about education. I'm interested in getting your thoughts on the importance placed on regulatory work versus educational work around digital literacy for civics education and people's ability to test whether something is a fact or an opinion. Are we better to pursue that path, noting that regulations can take a long time to come into effect. And also, even in my very uneducated experience with the digital landscape, I know it moves very, very quickly. I'm not sure that us, as legislators, can keep up with the speed at which the platforms change and influence the population. Are we better off investing heavily in digital education and literacy?

Dr Fordyce: Literacy is part of it. It's not going to be the full picture; in the face of a coordinated foreign campaign, literacy isn't going to be enough.

Mr BURNELL: Right.

Dr Fordyce: That said—while this isn't part of our research, it is part of our day-to-day lives as media educators—our young people do need better media literacy, and that will be part of helping them stay cognisant of what is happening in elections and being able to interpret online materials. This is perhaps getting to the point of personal opinion, but I do not think that we can do just media literacy alone if we are actually concerned about disinformation campaigns that are in any way strategic.

Dr Yang: I agree with both. In the literature that we've seen on misinformation, there is a term called 'prebunking'. You build up resistance to interpreting narratives that seem fishy, that seem wrong to you—these opinions that are off. That works as far as we can tell, as researchers. That is digital literacy. That is understanding what your platform is feeding you and why. It has the happy accident of working over a lot of life as well, not just electoral misinformation campaigns. That type of digital literacy works. And, in the face of an organised, strategic state based campaign, you need other measures.

Dr Fordyce: Also, I don't necessarily think that it moves that quickly. I don't think there's anything about the problems that we're dealing with here today that couldn't have seen some sort of progress 12 years ago, for instance.

Dr Yang: One thing I'd like to add is that the ongoing research work is very much needed. We are very used to academic research—getting grants and then finishing the research when the grant is completed. That is not going to be effective. We need ongoing work. RECapture started in 2019, and we have achieved some effective outcomes. When we were started we were a project. There was a very minimal amount of political advertisement being authorised on WeChat, and now, in 2025, we only see four per cent of political advertisements on WeChat not being authorised. The vast majority of them have been authorised. During the process—and I think we have published a lot—we have talked to journalists, media, fact checkers, politicians, political candidates and public services a lot in terms of 'this is what we have seen on WeChat, and this is the supervisory and research monitoring power that we have to change what is going on, to make positive change in terms of what is going on'.

Mr BURNELL: That actually segues nicely into my last question. Outside of RedNote, WeChat and YouTube, are there other platforms that you have identified that need to be more closely monitored? Outside of predominantly Chinese focused platforms, are there other interest groups that have been targeted by similar types of platforms? In closing, do we need to better fund the ability to research and be on top of this type of work?

Dr Heemsbergen: How quickly can I say, 'Sure!' That is our research question for 2026. Part of it is looking at where else to look, because we've been very successful in looking at this community's interaction with disinformation in the electoral system and what it means for Australia, and I think we would be motivated to be inclusive elsewhere.

Dr Fordyce: I would add that there are an increasing number of platforms that are not visible to researchers externally and that are very closed down. I'm thinking of, potentially, some kinds of Telegram channels. We have Discord, we have Slack, we have WhatsApp accounts—those sorts of things. We have a common history of public, open platforms that dominate a lot of our understanding of how news and information circulates. These are the Facebooks and the Twitters, and WhatsApp in its own way. But there are a large and increasing number of platforms that are not open—that researchers cannot access. I do not think we would be able to get any kind of productive relationship with the countries that run those services, to actually see inside those groups, and I think some of them are genuinely worrying.

Dr Yang: RECapture research provides us with a snapshot in terms of how closed digital systems work, and China's social media services are hard ones. Twitter and Facebook opened their API for researchers, where they provide a well-curated dataset for researchers and the public. You can't get anything from those Chinese language social media services. As we have mentioned, we largely rely on manual work at this stage. We'll roll out an

experiment or pilot to see how we can proceed with further research to look into closed digital systems, where disinformation has been circulated and people have trustingly relied on those information sources that we as outsiders cannot really verify.

Mr BURNELL: I want to pick up on that last point that you made, Dr Fordyce. So there's potentially a bigger problem with the platforms we can't see than with the platforms we can see?

Dr Fordyce: I think the platforms that we can't see are probably where some organisation happens for informal political groups such as extremists of different sorts. I think we will not be able to see inside those, at least not conventionally, and so monitoring the platforms that are public and open will give us insights into patterns of disinformation and insights into political agendas that we won't be able to see otherwise. I honestly don't see a way of us getting information on the inside of those groups without some sort of law enforcement approach.

CHAIR: Ms Campbell.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much for your report and the evidence you've provided today. We've had a lot of discussion in this committee about the role of the AEC with regard to providing in-language community based outreach for multicultural communities. In terms of these platforms, what do you see the AEC's role to be in communicating robust and accurate information about the election and its processes to multicultural communities?

Dr Yang: On WeChat we have identified 15 advertisements from the AEC. They were about disinformation, fact-checking, civic education, what an election is and why it is important. However, these advertisements did not gain as much engagement as we would expect. People would rather consume misleading information from non-official sources compared to the AEC, but we appreciate what the AEC presented on WeChat. We really appreciate their engagement on WeChat and their attempt on WeChat.

I think we had this point earlier on. In terms of political communication, platform specificity and audience specificity are very important. We need to understand who we're talking to, what their communication preferences are and what kind of language—not linguistic language but what kind of content and how we should curate our language—to use so that language can get into the mindset of our audience. We also identified instances during the Voice referendum a couple of years ago in which political advertisements from official sources got removed after the campaign was concluded. Not engaging with Chinese-language social services means that we just opened this void for actors who may promote disinformation for commercial or political purposes. So, yes, we do need official voices on those platforms, and, yes, those voices should be not just fit for purpose but also fit for the need of their audience.

Ms CAMPBELL: Effectively, you're saying that the AEC's communications on the platform that we're talking about weren't as effective, and presumably that means that they weren't getting the same kind of reach or frequency that some of the misleading information was. What are the ways in which the AEC could increase their effectiveness? What are the specific and tactical mechanisms that they could undertake to be more effective on this platform?

Dr Heemsbergen: Just one point for clarification on the effectiveness of the AEC's advertisements: I think that measure compared to other ads on the platform, so it was more that ads for strange and wonderful things were more interesting than those for electoral integrity. Because of that, I think that engagement outside of platform, engagement with community and consideration of how then to get those messages into the communities that get their news on these platforms would be a great focus to expand on. Again, we don't discount the work that the AEC is doing there, but it seems to be about community engagement with the community and having champions within the community—as we saw this morning, to be honest. That would be a great space to expand in.

Dr Yang: When it comes to the AEC's engagement, it often comes at election time. The work identifying misinformation is an ongoing phenomenon. We can't just promote official voices during that particular time and then—boom—switch the mentality for a community. That is not going to happen. So ongoing engagement is a necessity. If you want to provide effective civic education targeting the community now, don't wait till election time, because, during that time, lots of political information is going on. How we can get an official voice into the massive wave of information is the question, and that involves lots of risks and challenges.

Ms CAMPBELL: This committee has previously heard evidence regarding the number of informal ballots, primarily in multicultural areas, and the ongoing efforts of the AEC and others to improve those rates. Did anything come through in your research that went to informality of balloting—that is, misinformation about how to number a ballot or misunderstanding of the ways in which to exercise a valid vote?

Dr Yang: Our analysis is ongoing. So far, we don't have what disinformation is appearing at a specific date, but that is a direction we're going in with regard to intensity of disinformation narratives when we approach election time.

Dr Fordyce: One thing that we did identify that comes to mind is some disinformation on the WeChat platform that suggested that the date of the election was going to change due to the death of the Pope. Through the intervention of the AEC, the AEC was able to remediate that and correct people. That's the closest thing that comes to mind that we have addressed so far.

Dr Heemsbergen: We can look into our data more and get back to you on that, but that was the—

Ms CAMPBELL: Do we know who the information about the change of the date came from?

Dr Fordyce: No. We would have to look for that, and I cannot guarantee that it would have occurred or been generated within the platform. This may have happened elsewhere and then circulated on the platform.

Ms CAMPBELL: I understand. Finally, I was going to ask if you could please tell us a bit about the demographics of most of those who are participating in each of these platforms. Are we talking about a higher representation of women, older people, younger people, cities or regions in any of these particular platforms?

Dr Yang: The demographic features of the audience really varies, because different media outlets are on WeChat or on RedNote and face different audiences. Some of those outlets have focused on publishing news and information about finance, interest rates, exchange rates and the business between Australia and China, and they will have positioned their audience as upper-middle-class Chinese migrant communities. Some of those media outlets will target young Chinese international students. Some of those media outlets will target so-called general, average Chinese-language speakers in Australia. It really varies.

Ms CAMPBELL: Thank you very much. I really appreciate it.

CHAIR: Thanks for your evidence today. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, would you please forward it to the secretariat by Friday 28 November. I'd love to see some of the examples that you've referenced in your research and here today for what you've identified as disinformation and some details about when it appeared. If you could do that, that'd be great. Thank you.

Proceedings suspended from 12:24 to 13:00

BACHRACH, Ms Amy, Private capacity

BIRD, Ms Leonie, Private capacity

COUGHLAN, Mr Brian, Private capacity

COX, Mr Simon, Private capacity

GIBB, Ms Rosanne, Private capacity

GOTTLIEB, Mr Yaron, Private capacity

GROVES, Mr Michael, Private capacity

LEITCH, Dr Shirley, Private capacity

MORAN, Mr Rodney, Private capacity

STEPHEN, Mr Tony, Private capacity

TONCICH, Mr Carlo, Private capacity

CHAIR: Welcome, Mr Moran. Do you have any comments to make on the capacity in which you appear?

Mr Moran: I've been a volunteer for Zoe Daniel from before the 2022 election and was heavily involved in prepolling, polling and manning polling booths.

CHAIR: I now invite you to deliver a statement before we proceed to questions.

Mr Moran: I got involved in the campaign partly because of Zoe's focus on integrity and transparency, which she carried right through until mid-May. It's unfortunate that other groups and individuals in the election had a much lower bar of what they thought was acceptable. I feel compelled today to speak up because of some of the actions and incidents that I witnessed by other players in the election who were not really interested in integrity but merely in winning. As I say, the standards you walk by are the standards you accept, and I cannot accept what I saw.

I saw extreme-right-wing men bring a very large trailer with an extensive and expensive sound system, set up opposite the North Brighton polling booth and then yell their hate speech at all those who were volunteering or waiting in line to vote. Although this is expressly forbidden in the AEC act section 340, article 63 and 65, having the use of a sound system, because it was outside the six metres apparently there was nothing that could be done.

I saw people representing the third party Repeal the Teal engage in, in my view, voter intimidation by walking right up to those waiting in line and whispering not to vote Greens or independent, potentially intimidating voters and corrupting the electoral process. This tactic was clearly enunciated by the group in a 13 May article in the *Australian Jewish News* where they said that they had walked right up and down the lines of voters, talking to people. They said:

They didn't just stand there handing out a pamphlet, they were really engaging with the public.

They were pleased with their ability to 'contaminate the teal brand'—nothing positive. Again, this is expressly forbidden by article 63, which concerns canvassing voters or inducing any elector not to vote for any particular candidate. But because it was outside the six metres, again, there was nothing that could be done.

I saw some of these same people change their T-shirts from Repeal the Teal to the Liberal Party and then continue engaging with voters. This change actually occurred in the Liberal Party's tent, in full view, disguising who they really were supporting and thus potentially corrupting the electoral process.

I saw an overabundance of corflutes and signs, which seemed to go further and further down the streets away from the polling booth. And all candidates started to engage in an arms race to have the greatest amount of signage and highest number of volunteers. At the polling booth in Hotham, the Liberal candidate was heard to complain loudly and publicly that there were more signs for the Liberal candidate for Goldstein than they were for her in her own electorate.

I saw the Liberal candidate for Goldstein stand right on the six-metre line and invade the personal space of every voter, who had no choice but to walk past him, where he encouraged them to vote for him, again in apparent contravention of article 63. But because it was two centimetres beyond the six-metre line there was apparently nothing that could be done.

There were only two prepoll booths in Goldstein, one of which also served the neighbouring seat of Macnamara, and there was one in the neighbouring electorate of Isaacs where Goldstein voters could vote as well.

Therefore there was a potential for over 200,000 voters to be using these prepolling centres, so no wonder there were wait times of up to 30 minutes. If there is no increase in the number of electorates then the number of voters and the length of the lines for waiting to vote is not going to be lessened. It is important that they and the volunteers feel safe and not be intimidated.

There are rules in place now to deal with these activities: section 340 of the AEC Act, articles 62 to 65. But the exclusion zone needs to be extended beyond six metres so that voters do not run the risk of intimidatory behaviour or inducements to vote. Rest assured, these activities will only grow unless stopped. Repeal the Teal said in that same 13 May article that they would only grow their group and activities. And whose electorates are going to be targeted in 2028?

If the behaviour is unacceptable within six metres, why is it suddenly okay beyond six metres? Perhaps there can be different zones where different activities can take place—a red, an amber and a green zone. There needs to be a clear limit on the number of corflutes, the level of signage and the number of volunteers around each polling booth. It can really get over the top, as Dr Ryan had an issue with. But we all did, with there being so many signs and volunteers, which can be intimidating.

All third parties should be banned from being in attendance at any booth. The only people who should be there are those directly supporting one of the candidates. They have a greater stake in following the rules, whereas third parties can behave however they want to, knowing that they do not want to elect anybody but just stop other people from being elected.

There needs to be a separate group, perhaps under the auspices of the AEC, who look as though they have—and do have—power to enforce regulations at polling booths, especially beyond the six metres. This group could be a 'flying squad' who visit different booths daily, regularly and unannounced, in one or more electorates, to check on the compliance and consistency outside each booth they visit. This would allow those inside to concentrate on ensuring that votes are cast correctly and safely.

A clear notice needs to be placed outside each polling booth detailing what the Electoral Act does and does not allow within these zones. This is what the flying squad could be checking on and could also be pointed out to transgressors, which may well then stop the behaviour then and there.

CHAIR: Thank you for your considered submission. I would imagine that banning people from participating in an election would be unconstitutional. What treatment do you propose for third parties? From the evidence we've received so far—and I don't want to pre-empt the inquiry's findings—it seems to me, from the AEC today and from written submissions that it's this attention from third parties that lifted the heat.

Mr Moran: Yes.

CHAIR: From your experience, what information or what treatment would benefit voters as they come in to distinguish the difference?

Mr Moran: As I said, within six metres none of this activity can occur. So already the law is there. If the law is there and hasn't been challenged by anybody, what's the difference between that and 40 metres? That's what I'm saying. So there's the red zone, where nothing can happen within six metres. Then there might be a zone where only political parties and their representatives could be perhaps engaging with voters, but following those same guidelines. Then, after a certain number of metres, those restrictions stop. You're not stopping someone from expressing a political opinion; you are perhaps just limiting where they can say it—just like in a court of law, where there are things you can and can't do, and everyone accepts that.

CHAIR: Would the flying squad you suggested have the power to remove people from the booth if they broached these rules?

Mr Moran: Those changes could outline what they've done and therefore what's incorrect. They would have the power to call police. They would have the power to move people on. Already the AEC Act says that if any of these offences are committed then a court may impose a penalty of five penalty units. So it's already there.

CHAIR: We really appreciate your submission. Thank you, Mr Moran. If you've been asked to provide any additional information, please forward it to the secretariat by Friday 28 November. I might just say that once so I'm not wasting time for the rest.

I now invite you, Dr Leitch, to give evidence. Do you have any comments to make on the capacity in which you appear before the committee?

Dr Leitch: I'm speaking as a volunteer for Zoe Daniel—I have held various volunteer offices within Ms Daniel's campaign, but I am speaking as an individual, not on behalf of Ms Daniel or anybody else.

CHAIR: I now invite you to make your statement before we proceed to questions.

Dr Leitch: I did submit a joint submission to this committee, and I will take it that that has been read. My joint submission builds on my experience as a booth captain during the 2022 and 2025 federal elections. I was a witness to the significant increase in aggressive and intimidatory behaviours between those two elections. The increase in these appalling behaviours was such that I was concerned not just for the safety of the volunteers that I was organising but also for my own safety. These behaviours were the result of highly organised, well-resourced campaigns by third parties, who were not themselves running as candidates in the election. I'm sure you've heard that from others already.

I observed multiple incidents which did not seem to conform with existing legislation but which did not result in any penalty or any other action being taken. I also observed behaviours that were not aligned with the overall goal of providing a safe environment but which may not be covered by existing legislation. You will already have heard about these in great detail, I'm sure.

You will have heard of the unprecedented levels of third-party activism in Goldstein, and, during the prepolling period, the Brighton prepoll—that's where I was captain—was the epicentre of this activism. It began with massive billboards on the Nepean Highway, targeting the independent candidate; extended to attack advertising on social media and extensive leaflet drops across the electorate; and then homed in on individual households by defacing corflutes with libellous statements and then sending personalised poison-pen letters to householders.

Once prepolling began, the focus shifted to the few booths—and I want to emphasise that there were only a couple of booths in this big electorate—servicing everybody. Booths were blanketed with third-party attack advertising, and third-party workers harassed and intimidated our volunteers and voters. By way of context, over 2,200 voters, on average, passed through that booth every single day. Voters were almost always required to queue, often for periods of 15 minutes to 45 minutes, and much of this time was spent outside of the designated six-metre line that Mr Moran has talked about. I cannot overemphasise the importance of the six-metre line when third parties decide to target a booth. At Brighton, the necessity to queue beyond the six-metre line created ideal, captive and corralled conditions for third parties to target, harass and intimidate volunteers and voters.

I offer the following, practical recommendations to address the situation. Firstly, increase the number of prepoll booths in electorates such as Goldstein to reduce the numbers at each booth and reduce the possibility that queuing voters can be targeted for lengthy periods of time outside the six-metre line.

Secondly, give greater discretion to the AEC to designate the six-metre line—I think Mr Moran has made some recommendations in line with this as well—and put it in such a place as to reduce the possibility of queues forming beyond it. Presently, AEC seems to have quite limited discretion, mostly in relation to schools, so perhaps the six-metre concept should be abandoned entirely, and it should be replaced by a generic rule that the AEC has the right to determine the position beyond which campaign volunteer activity of any kind cannot occur. In the case of the Brighton prepoll, the so-called six-metre line was drawn in two different places in any case in 2022 and 2025, and no explanation was really offered for that. While the 2022 placement would not have prevented voters being exposed to harassment and intimidation, it would have reduced the harassment zone and resulted in a safer voter experience by increasing that no-go area.

My third recommendation is to remove the right of anyone other than a candidate or a party who are contesting that seat to display or distribute materials within a designated distance of a prepoll or polling booth. I would suggest 200 metres. I'm not trying to shut down freedom of speech; I'm just trying to recommend things that will stop harassment and intimidation.

My fourth recommendation is to make it an offence to physically approach a voter once they've joined a queue for prepoll or a polling booth without invitation to do so and confine verbal interactions with voters outside that six-metre line to offering an official how-to-vote card for a candidate.

I want to highlight a particular incident that occurred at the Brighton prepoll, because I fear that it was so intimidating, and I'm scared that it's going to set such a precedent that I fear for the physical safety of volunteers and voters at the next election. On the last day of prepolling, the far-right group the National Socialist Network targeted the Brighton prepoll. At around 3 pm, when the queue was consistently 20 minutes or more, a truck stopped opposite the entrance to the prepoll booth, and men dressed in black offloaded very large speakers and sound equipment—massive things. They proceeded to broadcast at loud volumes anti-immigration, racist and other offensive messaging for around an hour. Their messages included direct attacks on the Goldstein candidates—all of the Goldstein candidates. The queue went very quiet. Parents were covering the ears of their children. People were frightened. There were shocked looks.

The AEC manager was called out. He responded by calling the police, who took over 20 minutes to arrive. They did nothing. They watched from a distance and said they couldn't do anything. Prior to this incident, the

AEC manager had advised campaign volunteers that they couldn't even play music that was audible inside the six-metre line. The relevant portion of the Commonwealth Electoral Act is section 340, on the prohibition of certain behaviours. I would recommend that you empower the AEC to request the police remove people from the vicinity of booths who they judge to be acting in violation of the Commonwealth Electoral Act. Where these actions include the use of equipment leading to the broadcast of sound audible at the six-metre line, I would recommend that police be authorised to confiscate that equipment for the period of the election.

My final recommendation is that, when the AEC deem that there is potential for further threatening, disruptive or other illegal behaviour to occur at a prepoll or a polling booth, the AEC be empowered to request that a visible police presence be maintained at that booth during opening hours. I can't overemphasise the importance of this. The combined effect of third-party activism at the Brighton prepoll was to create an environment dominated by these groups, rather than by the candidates actually contesting the seat. While a candidate might be held publicly accountable and might therefore pull back from openly harassing and slandering people, similar constraints are not in place for third-party groups. The reformed act does not address this issue. Given the caps that will be in place on expenditures by candidates, parties and disclosure entities, there are now even stronger incentives in place for these significant third-party groups to form and to proliferate.

CHAIR: What impact do you think this had on voters?

Dr Leitch: Voters were frightened. Voters were scared. Particularly when the far-right group was there, I saw people who were obviously relatively recent immigrants just looking shocked and looking like they wanted to run away from the voting booth.

CHAIR: Did you witness anyone leaving?

Dr Leitch: I didn't witness anyone leaving, but I did witness people in tears. I did witness a lot of shocked behaviour. The queue was so long that I couldn't necessarily see.

CHAIR: Sure.

Mr BURNELL: With the recommendation that you suggest around sound devices being used in polling booths, do you want carte blanche restriction on them completely, or is it only in the cases where there's a nefarious intent?

Dr Leitch: They are already restricted under the existing act. You're not supposed to actually play anything that's audible within the six-metre line. It's not enforced at the moment.

Mr BURNELL: For clarity, there shouldn't be anybody within the six-metre zone trying to solicit a vote from somebody there to cast a vote. So everybody should be outside of that six-metre zone; therefore, the audible device would be outside the six-metre zone. Is that being breached at some of them?

Dr Leitch: It's being breached, because the way I read the legislation is that it shouldn't be audible. The device doesn't have to be within the six-metre line. It shouldn't be audible. I think the intent of the act was to stop somebody standing with any kind of device and broadcasting so they can hear it. Volunteers were not allowed to do that. We weren't allowed to even play music.

Mr BURNELL: That's the issue.

Dr Leitch: So, yes. And I think for anyone who refuses to comply with that, as this particular group did, rather than just saying, 'Oh, okay; you refuse to comply,' and doing nothing, the devices should be confiscated.

CHAIR: Thank you, Dr Leitch. Mr Gottlieb, please give your statement, and then I will open up to questions.

Mr Gottlieb: Thank you, Chair and members of the committee, for the opportunity to speak. I am not here on behalf of any party or candidate. During the election I was employed as the data analyst for the Zoe Daniel campaign, and in the past I've been employed as a communal rabbi.

It is first necessary in this statement to distinguish between antisemitism and antisemites. Most people, I have found, are not antisemites. However, antisemitism tropes are used in regular political discourse because people are not aware of the origins of the words—such as Tim Wilson, who, in yesterday's *Age,* used the word 'globalist', which is a shorthand in many antisemitic groups. Even Jews will often unknowingly make antisemitic statements.

A key element of the campaign in Goldstein was the weaponisation of antisemitism. There was a push by some to label all political opponents as anti-Semites, especially in the Jewish neighbourhoods. This was a deliberate tactic by the Liberals and their affiliated third-party organisations to damage their opponents. This conduct went far beyond the ordinary political contest. Jewish volunteers were abused as traitors, self-hating Jews and kapos. Volunteers were spat on, followed, filmed and threatened. I was regularly abused at polling stations and once when collecting my children from school. There were also reports of abuse of students in school playgrounds.

As part of my responsibilities during the campaign, I visited the Malvern, Brighton and Oakleigh voting centres. Bullying and intimidation were regular features at Malvern and Brighton. Volunteers and voters would be targeted, to bully people into supporting their candidates. However, at Oakley, which is a distance from the Jewish community, there was none of that behaviour.

Because of the history of antisemitism, there is an inclination in the Jewish community to stamp out even the smallest example of antisemitism before it can take root. The Liberals sought to exploit this fear within the community. They pushed the false narrative that other candidates were antisemitic or would betray the community. I often heard people say, 'Jews must vote for Wilson,' thus spreading this antisemitic trope.

During the campaign, some communal institutions campaigned for preferred candidates. One example was the letter sent out by Catholic schools falsely claiming that Zoe would undermine their funding. When communal organisations become partisan, they alienate portions of their communities, causing a breakdown in social cohesion. It's a dangerous lie for Jews to become synonymous with one party, and it could potentially put a target on our backs. It is also a false reality. Jews support all candidates across the ideological spectrum. This failure of leadership within the Jewish community caused a deterioration in mental health and feelings of communal alienation amongst the Jewish volunteers. There were also campaigns supporting this. Synagogues and communal spaces provided a pulpit for thinly veiled campaign rallies.

As recommendations, the AEC should be able to make faster decisions and conclude deliberations during the campaign period. It does not help if an offender is a sitting MP by the time a decision is delivered. Political parties should face more stringent consequences for misconduct. Fines do not deter bad behaviour. Candidates found guilty of wrongdoing should face the penalty of losing votes. This would be a stronger deterrent than a monetary fine. Communal organisations such as houses of worship and schools, especially those receiving government funding, should be barred from endorsing candidates. They should still be able to advocate for specific policies.

I'd also like to make a few statements about postal votes. Political parties use postal applications to data-harvest voters' details by making the return address the party HQ rather than AEC. This gives a partisan advantage, since they alone know the details of these voters and can contact them directly. General postal voters are available to all campaigns through the electoral roll but only make up a fraction of postal voters. Postal voters don't turn up at polling booths, so campaigns are limited in their ability to communicate with these voters.

I would recommend that all postal applications must be addressed directly to the AEC, as is the case in Victorian law at the moment. Each candidate should receive a list of postal vote applicants, updated daily through the election campaign, to assist with communication. The AEC should provide how-to-vote cards of all candidates with the postal votes if the cards are provided by the candidates—so you put the how-to-vote cards in the envelope.

This is not about one electorate or one community; it's bigger than that. It's also not about the margin of 175 votes in Goldstein, where almost any single data point could flip the results. If fear and intimidation become accepted tools of political strategy, we'll all ultimately lose. We must reaffirm that every Australian, of every faith and background, must be able to participate in the democratic process without being bullied or harassed.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mr Gottlieb. In the examples that you mention where volunteers were spat on, followed, filmed or threatened, in your experience, was that at prepoll or was that at polling booths on the Saturday?

Mr Gottlieb: There was some stuff like that at prepoll. It was also in general campaigning. In my written submission, I had a questionnaire that went out to volunteers. I got—I can't remember the exact number now off the top of my head—several dozen responses, and I formulated that within my submission.

CHAIR: In your submission—okay, thank you. You mentioned you are a data analyst. Without going into too much detail about what you did, was there anything that you were picking up in what you were receiving that was of note, particularly in relation to whether or not people would participate in the electoral process? My fear is that this behaviour would discourage people from participating.

Mr Gottlieb: There was. That was more in the survey that I sent out. There were people saying that. One of the questions was, 'Did you refrain from doing these different activities?' Almost everyone refrained from at least one activity during the campaign period.

CHAIR: And other bits of evidence have mentioned third parties and their involvement. In your opinion, was it that heightened concentration of third parties in Goldstein the led to that type of behaviour occurring? Or does it all come back to the—

Mr Gottlieb: If you're asking for my opinion, I would say that there was collusion between campaigns and third parties.

CHAIR: Do you have any evidence of that?

Mr Gottlieb: Well, we've seen, from other people, that they swapped—

CHAIR: Shirts.

Mr Gottlieb: shirts, and just knowing the people who were on these campaigns, I know that some of them were Liberal Party members—not necessarily active, but they are part of the overall—

CHAIR: Yes. Thank you. Any other questions?

Dr RYAN: I have one. It's been very consistent—we've heard it from many people—that the issues have been more significant at prepoll than at polling booths on the election day. Is one of the answers to limit the number of people who can vote at prepoll? Or is it to have more prepoll sites? Or is it just to change the rules around behaviour overall?

Mr Gottlieb: I think you don't want to be limiting prepoll. That's when you start running down the path of America, where they're restricting people. I've always voted prepoll because I can't do it on Saturday.

Dr RYAN: I guess that's part of it. It used to be that you had to have a reason. Now you just have to show up and say, 'I have a reason.'

Mr Gottlieb: I just feel that we want to give people—it's also from the side of the voters—the maximum amount of opportunity to get to the polls. I think any restricting of that is not a good thing.

Dr RYAN: So should we have more prepoll sites—

Mr Gottlieb: Yes.

Dr RYAN: and/or should we change the behaviour?

Mr Gottlieb: I think a few things. I think the first thing is that we want to expand the number of prepoll sites in an electorate, but we also want to limit people's ability to cast an ordinary vote outside of their electorate. For example, for us, in our list we had Oakleigh and Malvern, which had under 1,000 votes across two weeks, and Melbourne, which had I think 170, or 120 or something like that. So we have these booths where no Goldstein voters were actually showing up, but we had to put volunteers there; we had to consider that. A party that's running in every seat has volunteers at every booth. So if we could get another booth within Goldstein that would be good, and then limit the access to those booths that are well outside our boundaries.

Senator GROGAN: From a lot of what we've heard today about some of the challenges on polling booths and how the queues went and the difficulties and such like, do you feel, from your experience, that going to a four-year fixed scenario—which would mean the AEC would be able to lock in more-appropriate venues—would make a difference to some of the issues you've seen?

Mr Gottlieb: I think we absolutely should be going to fixed terms. I think we're all a bit referendum-shy at the moment, but I think we should be having more referendums. Again, look at my submission for that. I think fixed terms would definitely help, and if we're going to do it, it should be about where it is now. Because of the 1 July start for the Senate, I think it's appropriate to have the election some time in the first few weeks of May.

Senator GROGAN: Just for clarity: currently an election can be called from the preceding August, effectively.

Mr Gottlieb: Yes.

Senator GROGAN: And the AEC has to have all the sites, or enough sites in every electorate, to cater.

Mr Gottlieb: And you run into the problem of the motoring enthusiast guy, who was basically unemployed for nine or 10 months because no-one wanted to employ someone who had a job as a senator coming up. Yes, I think we should be looking at May. Would it improve? I don't think fixed terms would be a solution to this, no.

CHAIR: We're going to have to end it there, Senator. Thank you very much for your evidence today, Mr Gottlieb. I now call Mr Coughlan.

Mr Coughlan: I'm a novice volunteer, and, like many of the people who served on this campaign, I have not been involved in politics before. I'm representing the seat of Goldstein in the sense that I was a volunteer for the Independent candidate, as many in this room have been. I think you've already heard the complaints that have come out.

I place my submission before the committee. There are two individual complaints, which I won't repeat, but essentially one person in the Liberal Party volunteer group accused our candidate of antisemitism. It was quite a volatile meeting at the prepoll booth. I was involved as a coordinator of our volunteers at the Hampton prepoll for two weeks, with some other people to assist me of course, and I was also involved in a polling booth on the day of

the election. Both of these incidents happened, one at each place, and they were both really confronting. The whole process, as you've heard, has been confronting as an individual, and it has been really—the passion that we all feel here today is to represent our candidate. We are aggrieved by what we were confronted with, and that's one of the reasons why we'd like to make submissions to the committee.

I think most of us are here with the understanding that it is difficult to make changes. I was also involved in scrutineering, and the scrutineering process was both challenging and exciting, but one can only say that our democracy is so much better served with having an AEC. We are very fortunate with the AEC. I commend the AEC for the process of scrutineering. It was really difficult—we lost by a close margin and there was some very aggressive behaviour there too—but that's the political process. Scrutineering is a challenging scenario, but it's a worthwhile one.

Some people have recommended the notion of signs. One of the things I was distressed about, at the prepoll booth I counted 25 of our signs and 25 of the Liberal signs. Is that necessary? The AEC should limit the number of signs so that people can walk to the booth without being inundated. Most people have a general inclination as to which way they're going to vote. There are some people who are going to change, but they don't need this tunnel of signs as they approach a polling booth. It's really intimidating for voters.

I was involved in the 2022 campaign. We had a reasonably amicable relationship with the people on our booth, and we tried to foster that in the prepoll and the polling booth on election day 2025, but it was a completely different scenario. There was so much more aggression. In my view, it doesn't seem fair that a third party can spend $1½ million—the Advance Australia and the Repeal the Teal groups contributed $1½ million dollars. The Liberal Party funding in the seat of Goldstein is unknown, as is the Labor Party funding. I think that is unfair. It's really unfair. The independent candidates, and Monique would know about this more than I do—it's unfair that third-party candidates, third-party lobby groups, can contribute so much to the funding. You can talk about Clive Palmer; you can talk about lots of different groups. We had an animal liberation group at our polling booth, and that was relatively benign compared to the other polling groups. The third-party Repeal the Teal—you cannot refute antisemitism, as Yaron has just said. If people accuse you of antisemitism, it's just a blanket description. We presented data to the voters that Zoe was not antisemitic, and it was really difficult to refute. The same can be said for lots of things. Lies in political advertising have already been covered. Trying to refute that notion is really problematic in the hustle and bustle of a polling booth. I think something needs to be done about truth in political advertising and, more particularly, as a minor point, in the signage that is presented to voters as they come to a polling booth.

CHAIR: Just to be clear—you take offence to the amount that people can spend during an election campaign. You mentioned the limit.

Mr Coughlan: Clive Palmer's spending—we all think that's horrendous.

CHAIR: You don't want that big money influence.

Mr Coughlan: To have $1½ million allegedly spent by third-party candidates—in support of the Liberal candidate, mind you—is really unfair and, in my view, unforgivable. They used their forum to lie about our candidate, and it was once again difficult to refute. There was lots of money involved. You would have heard about the social media and their signs. We stood behinds signs saying, 'Zoe votes with the Greens.' It was really difficult to refute. You can say that it's not true, but the voters are being faced with that all the time. There should be some sort of process that the AEC is involved in that stops that sort of behaviour, in my view.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell, did you have some questions on the scrutineering process?

Mr BURNELL: I wanted to tease out the comments you just made about inappropriate behaviour during the scrutineering process. Could you talk us through the behaviour that was experienced.

Mr Coughlan: There was a bit of argy-bargy. I'm sure you have all been involved in it yourselves.

CHAIR: No, we can't; we're the candidates!

Mr Coughlan: Oh yes, you're the candidates.

CHAIR: We're not allowed to do that. I wish I could.

Mr BURNELL: I've scrutineered before, but I've never experienced an environment where—

Mr Coughlan: People are sort of shouldering you out of your position. It's just a little bit physical. The AEC do a fantastic job—I've said that—and they do a good job with scrutineering, but it is quite a threatening process for a novice to go along to a scrutineering session and know how to behave and to challenge votes.

Mr BURNELL: Were you hit with a shoulder or—

Mr Coughlan: It was just aggressive behaviour in challenging a vote.

Mr BURNELL: I'm not trying to be rude, but I think it's important for this hearing to understand the type of behaviour that was demonstrated inside the scrutineering place, because this is supposed to be a space that is free of fear or favour et cetera. It is there for an observation, for the scrutiny of the vote that has been cast by an individual by either party or candidate that chooses to have somebody present to oversee the vote. So I'm really interested to understand explicitly what type of behaviour was experienced inside that place that has made you feel like you need to say something on the record here today.

Mr Coughlan: Maybe I'm speaking out of turn, because, in large part, the AEC do a good job, and they can't be everywhere. There is one coordinator for a room. There might be 30 tables, and that coordinator can't be everywhere. Some individuals are prone to be aggressive, and dealing with that aggression was a difficult part for me. I wasn't part of the campaign. No-one else in the campaign who I've spoken to found it difficult, but I did find the process intimidating in part. Eighty per cent of it was fine. It was just an intimidating process. I can't accuse the Liberal Party of being overtly aggressive. I just thought it was part of the process of politics.

Mr BURNELL: I've been involved, on several occasions, in scrutineering votes, and I've never experienced aggressive physical behaviour in that time; it's not something I've been exposed to. That's why my ears pricked up on this matter. It's not something that I think anyone should be experiencing inside a scrutineering booth.

Senator GROGAN: Can I just say something? Mr Burnell is right—it shouldn't, but I totally get where you're coming from, and I have seen it happen: people standing in front of others and being aggressive. So thank you for coming forward.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mr Coughlan. I'll call on Michael Groves and Rosanne Gibb.

Mr Gottlieb: Sorry, can I add, just briefly, that I've referenced my written submission. I actually put in two written submissions. I think, each time I mentioned it, it was in a different one.

CHAIR: We'll refer to them. Thank you. Mr Groves, do you have any comments to make about the capacity in which you appear?

Mr Groves: I'm appearing as an individual who has participated in the election campaign—and not only in this one but others, going way to back to 2013, across three seats in regional Victoria; Higgins in 2016; and the last two in Goldstein.

CHAIR: Thank you. Please feel free to make a statement.

Mr Groves: Good afternoon, everyone. Thanks for the opportunity to speak. I'd particularly like to share my experience in four areas. I'll state what they are first. One is intimidation of residents in their homes. I worked as a corflute installer—and a heavy maintainer of them, as the campaign rolled on—all over the electorate. But, in particular, what happened around the south Caulfield area, and in the bayside sections of Hampton and Sandringham, and parts of Highett, was really intimidating people who'd had the courage to put their signs up. There was also intimidation of the public. I attended the Jewish community candidate forum in east Brighton in early April. There was intimidation of the public, particularly at prepoll—it was the most intense. I was a prepoll booth volunteer. And also, on election day, I saw pretty heavy intimidation of volunteers who were campaigning for Zoe Daniel and also the Greens. That's not my remit, but I'll say it happened to both.

Firstly, on the corflute intimidation, the most shocking example I came across was when I got a call one or two days before election day and a resident in south Caulfield had requested a corflute to be put on her front fence in the morning. I got the notification and went there. I was installing it at about 3 pm that day when she came dashing out of the house and said, 'I've changed my mind.' I said, 'Oh, what's happened?' She quoted the letter that I think a number of us have seen on the ABC program. I'll just read the words out in case anybody doesn't know. It says: 'Your obvious and visible support as displayed in your front garden and gate shows your neighbours that you are antisemitic just like Zoe Daniel, the teal Green. You and your family are no longer welcome in our neighbourhood.' It seemed that anybody who put a corflute up got this, and she'd pulled out because she had been speaking to friends who had got these letters and advised her against it. She then refused to put the sign up—understandably.

Senator GROGAN: She didn't get a letter?

Mr Groves: No, she didn't.

Senator GROGAN: Good.

Mr Groves: I found this disgusting and very un-Australian—to intimidate somebody like that in their own home. I thought it was the highest level.

The next level down was the systematic vandalising, I guess you'd call it, of Zoe Daniel signs in various pockets. I can remember the one in Beaumaris. I was on the check group in the team, and every morning there'd be 10, 12 or 15 houses within a one-kilometre pocket that had been done over in the night. There would be fabulous things. The worst one was 'Jew hunter', a particularly pernicious reference to a ruthless Nazi character in the *Inglourious Basterds* film, and there were other offensive comments written everywhere. I really found that pretty bad.

In terms of the election process, somebody would volunteer in good faith and then spend an amazing amount of time in the last week before the election going around cleaning signs. We shared recipes for getting certain kinds of graffiti off the signs; I became an expert in the end. It was a shocking impression for the passers-by of that neighbourhood, who were forced to witness this happening every day. They'd walk past in daylight hours, and the sign would be clean. By nine o'clock the next morning, it was the same again.

The Jewish community event at East Brighton synagogue in early April was where I saw, for the first time, the Repeal the Teal and Better Australia groups in action. I felt they were a really obnoxious force that was further harassing our threatened Jewish community, who were trying to talk about some very sensitive, important matters in their own community facility. I found it unconscionable. Their behaviour in a house of worship was disgraceful and even worse, given the specific request from the rabbi hosting the event to maintain courtesy to all members on the onstage panel; that had no effect. Better Australia had a mobile electronic billboard, a massive unit, placed outside the synagogue, blasting out into the night sky. It was multicoloured and extremely bright—you were wincing as you went past, from the brightness of it. One thing about houses of worship—probably specifically synagogues; I don't know—is that they often don't draw great attention to themselves if they are concerned about their safety. This massive billboard was sitting outside an otherwise inconspicuous synagogue a couple of streets away from me. If I were in the Jewish community—which I'm not—I would have thought that my place of worship, which used to be fairly inconspicuous, was now being advertised to the world. I was really worried about that.

The other is probably just following on from what everybody else has said. At prepoll I had a Goldstein resident come up to me; she was horrified by what had happened. She said: 'My husband is bringing our 18-year-old daughter to vote this afternoon. I don't know what to do.' I thought quickly enough and asked a colleague. They said: 'Why don't you go off to that other booth? It hasn't been as wild as this.' What a terrible impression to give an 18-year-old coming up to vote for the first time. I heard stories on the radio of 18-year-olds. They'd say something on the way in to somebody and, as they came out, they'd be given a round of applause by all campaigners for all the sides—a joyous experience, but not for this poor girl, who was petrified going in because her mother had warned her how bad it was going to be. It was terrible. I think I'll skip the last one. It was a minor one.

CHAIR: Mr Groves, did you say that that letter, which went around to people who had signs, was reported on by the ABC?

Mr Groves: Yes.

CHAIR: It was? Okay. Do you have a copy of it? Has it been submitted to us in evidence?

Mr Groves: I believe it's in the submission put through by the Goldstein team.

CHAIR: Great. If it's not there, I'm sure we'll be in touch. Do you know if it was authorised?

Mr Groves: No.

CHAIR: It wasn't authorised?

Mr Groves: It was blank.

CHAIR: Thank you. I can relate to that last story you mentioned. I've got young children. I was in a marginal seat, and I didn't know if I was going to get re-elected. I wanted them to come and experience polling day with me for the last few hours, but, because of behaviour such as you have described, I had to leave them at home. And that was a really hard decision to make. Thanks for your evidence.

Ms Gibb: Thank you very much for the opportunity to speak today. I participated in both the 2022 and 2025 elections as a volunteer for Zoe Daniel along with the—I don't know the exact number—1,300 or so other volunteers. I was quite a political rookie in 2022. I'd recently retired and I felt very privileged that I had the time to put in, even in a small way, on issues that I felt were important to me, my children and my grandchildren. I felt very privileged that I could do this. At each election, we letterboxed, handed out flyers and doorknocked. It was a very steep learning curve, and we found ourselves contributing in ways that were well outside our comfort zones; it was such a good experience. I was also involved in the prepoll. On election day I was a co-captain.

In 2022 the whole experience was overwhelmingly positive. At prepoll I was really impressed. I saw all the candidates. There was no evidence of security, and I felt really proud of our very respectful democracy. It was almost a rainbow of different coloured T-shirts. Through that whole prepoll, in 2022, I only experienced one instance of verbal abuse, and that was by a Clive Palmer volunteer in a T-shirt. I didn't experience any other verbal abuse. But 2025, as so many others have said today, was such a different experience.

I was co-captain at Hampton prepoll as well as at a booth on election day. I should say that some of the Liberal volunteers were respectful and were good to work alongside, but others were just not. At times the atmosphere was aggressive and quite toxic. Other speakers have described specific instances. As volunteers, we were verbally abused by Liberal volunteers and some Liberal voters. They'd walk past us and wave their how-to-vote cards under our nose. It was really unpleasant.

At Hampton we didn't have any of the other third parties that Brighton experienced. But there was still the corflutes there expounding their disinformation; they were ever-present. It was interesting that Liberal voters felt emboldened to abuse us. Did that demonstrate a desperation for their candidate to be elected or a sense that they were almost given licence by the lies that had been expressed from a high level? Whose responsibility is that behaviour? While I understand that the atmosphere at Hampton wasn't nearly as tense as at Brighton, there were still times when, at the end of a shift, I would phone one of the volunteers to check that they were okay because I think we all went home feeling quite abused. I also want to acknowledge the Jewish speakers here today. They have all spoken about how their experiences affected them on a much deeper level. I felt bruised, but they were obviously much more affected.

As volunteers for Zoe Daniel, when we bought merchandise we agreed to abide by the Goldstein standard of treating all people with respect. Certainly, when I wore my T-shirt out in public I felt a real responsibility to present the best version of myself. It was a feeling expressed by many other volunteers. We felt we had to behave respectfully.

Since the election I've reflected on just why I felt emotionally bruised by the end. It concerned me, and it was more than just sour grapes that Zoe Daniel wasn't returned to Canberra. We felt bruised even before the results of the election. We have all heard that there is an increase in cynicism in this country regarding politics. I think one of the sad things about the 2025 election is that many volunteers, who showed real courage in wearing a T-shirt in public and putting themselves out there, may think twice before being involved next time, and that's a really sad reflection on the way that we were treated. We should feel proud that in this country we can don a T-shirt of whatever colour we choose and take part in a democratic process. It's not good if people are scared of that, and I think democracy will be all the poorer if volunteers are afraid to take part. So I believe there should be a code of conduct for everyone who represents a candidate, with accountability for any poor behaviour. I think the candidate needs some level of responsibility for their volunteers—and other speakers have mentioned that—whether it's a fine or whether they lose votes if there is poor behaviour. There needs to be some accountability.

CHAIR: I think what sets our democracy apart from others—and I think it's why it's been around for so long in Australia—is that high level of participation. I think participation rates were up this election compared to the one before—over 90 per cent. I'm concerned about the impact of the 2025 election on the participation of people in this room and also voters. Could you perhaps expand on the point you made in your verbal submission there about volunteers being less likely to participate. Do you have—

Ms Gibb: I have no proof of this—

CHAIR: Yes, sure.

Ms Gibb: but volunteers who experience the sort of abuse that we did at prepoll will speak to their friends about it. I think it could lead to a reluctance to put their hands up as volunteers at the next election.

CHAIR: Why is that?

Ms Gibb: The 2022 election was really quite an uplifting experience to be part of, but, I think, for people to voluntarily put themselves in a situation where they could be verbally abused, they've got to be pretty brave to turn up again the next day. If it happens once at prepoll, are they going to be willing to turn up the next day? I will, next time—but I think some people will think twice. And I think that's really sad.

CHAIR: What do you think the impact was on voters of having to stand in a queue at prepoll for half an hour witnessing this?

Ms Gibb: As I've said, Hampton wasn't nearly as bad as Brighton, but it was an unpleasant atmosphere to be part of. It was quite noisy at times. As co-captains, we encouraged our volunteers to really keep quiet—to just be smiling and handing out the information rather than bombarding them with more verbal noise, because it did get

quite noisy at times. As I say, it was nothing like Brighton, which, I think, took it to another level. I don't know if that answers the question.

CHAIR: It's good to get that on the record.

Ms Gibb: Thank you.

CHAIR: Dr Ryan, do you have any questions?

Dr RYAN: No, thank you. I'm in furious agreement with everything you've both said!

Mr BURNELL: The only thing I would say is probably more of a statement than a question. You talk about that sense of pride in being able to wear your T-shirt and help as a volunteer. Before being elected, what I used to look forward to every election campaign, whether it was state or federal, was the ability to put on the shirt of your chosen representative, for whom you wanted to go out and electioneer, and try and help influence an outcome. If we lose that, we lose the very essence of what makes our democracy so good.

Ms Gibb: Absolutely, and I think, in 2022, I felt that was to be celebrated. There was a rainbow on prepoll. And it takes courage to get out and about in public with your chosen T-shirt.

Mr BURNELL: Not everyone wants to vote for you all of the time.

Ms Gibb: No.

Mr BURNELL: My wife reminds me of that on a daily basis!

Ms Gibb: But it takes courage.

Mr BURNELL: It certainly does.

CHAIR: Thanks very much for your evidence.

Ms Gibb: Thank you very much.

CHAIR: We've got Leonie Bird and Carlo Toncich next, please. Ms Bird, do you have any comments to make on the capacity in which you appear before the committee?

Ms Bird: I appear in my capacity as a warden, pastoral care worker and child safety officer of St George's Anglican Church in Malvern. Its relevance to these proceedings is that St George's Anglican Church entered into a licence agreement with the AEC and therefore became a major voting centre in the 2025 federal election. But it has traditionally been, for some years, a voting centre.

CHAIR: Can you clarify that you were prepoll this time but previously just a voting centre.

Ms Bird: No, it's been a prepoll centre for a number of elections. And, as a matter of candour, openness and transparency, I indicate that I have been acting as a volunteer in Dr Monique Ryan's campaign.

CHAIR: Thank you.

Ms Bird: You have before you a statement in relation to how a voting centre functioned during the 2025 election, what happened to that voting centre and how it was affected. This was by way of a licence which was entered into with the AEC, which set out that, in fact, it was to promote the obligations and duties of the AEC in conducting that election.

I won't go through the entire written submission; you have that before you. Between about 22 April and 3 May, the AEC supervised and assisted voters at St George's voting centre. We found that, beyond the jurisdiction of the AEC, there was interference with the church and its church property. In particular, I refer you to clause 10(a), (b), (c) and (d) of my submission. Political notices were affixed to the church flagpole. A political marquee was erected on church grounds, without being applied for and without permission, by representatives of the Liberal Party. Despite a previous request to remove a political marquee, another one was erected the following day and a further request had to be made to remove that marquee. There had been an application on behalf of Dr Ryan's campaign for such a marquee. On the basis we were anxious to keep the political neutrality of that voting centre sacrosanct, that application was refused; if you give to one, you've got to give to the others.

Within the grounds I've been advised that there was an excessive amount of advertising for all parties, including wall-to-wall corflutes, various hoardings, material banner stretched between trees and a dozen umbrellas at times. What was concerning particularly to the people of St George's was that there was an incursion into what we call the memorial garden, which is a place where the ashes of deceased people are buried. That, for us, as in most other Anglican parishes, is consecrated ground.

I refer the committee to the schedule I've attached to my submission, which gives you a schematised layout of where the actual voting centre was, in the church hall. It's a very large area. It places the AEC with really good facilities; there are disability facilities, with access for people who are disabled who need to come to the polling

booth. We felt concerned that this was supposedly privately owned land, and St George's, in fact, was providing a licence to people to come onto St George's property, which is owned by the church, to participate in the election. St George's has served this community for more than 150 years. We treasure the opportunity to enter into these licences, as a service to the community of Malvern.

To short-circuit the submission, I refer the committee to the Victorian Electoral Commission's issued determination 003/2022. Rather than an individual idea of regulation, I submit that, in fact, that Victorian Electoral Commission determination would assist this committee in the limits that should be placed on the conduct of voting centres. Very quickly, without wasting your time, this sets out, among a lot of other things, how signs need to be erected or not erected around a voting place and that there be a limit of 100 metres from a designated entrance to a voting centre—that is, that the jurisdiction of the AEC be extended so they have jurisdiction to control what is going on around the voting centre. This determination also sets out that notices or signs relating to an election should be displayed within a certain zone, and that each candidate have a limitation on the displays they're allowed to have, a limitation on registered parties' displays and a limitation on the weight and size of the signage. That may not be what the federal jurisdiction wishes to impose, but my submission to you, with respect, is that it's a starting point for something that is already recognisable in Victoria. I'm assuming, then, that this would apply to this coming state election. But I'm urging the committee to look carefully at this formulation in reframing how voting centres are to be, well, policed in some ways.

With your permission, perhaps I might add further comments to what has already been put before you. Some of the displays of behaviour, including harassment, stalking and threats, are already part of the Criminal Code in Victoria. You're not allowed to stalk people, under the Criminal Code. You're not allowed to harass. If you look at the sections on personal safety intervention orders, it says you're not allowed to have conduct that is likely to intimidate, humiliate or embarrass people. The problem is, all of us are subject to these things, but the mechanism for enforcement isn't available to people who participate in the electoral process. It sounds harsh, but in fact, if somebody wanted to pursue it, we're looking at trespass to persons or trespass to property. But it doesn't hurt, I think, to place some degree of weight on what other jurisdictions in Victoria indicate that there are breaches of—seriously.

I don't know about you, but I've been really distressed by hearing some of this evidence this afternoon. My view—and I'm putting it to you with my submission—is that this is not the way Australian democracy should be functioning. I won't go on any further, because I know your time is valuable and limited. But I am very concerned and very conscious that in speaking to all of you today I'm speaking to the parliament of Australia. That means a great deal to me, and I think the parliament and this committee should be congratulated for the work it's doing, because in the long term it's for all of us and our benefit.

CHAIR: Thank you. I have a very brief question. You've mentioned that St George's Anglican has been doing this for quite some time. What was feedback from your parishioners and your members from seeing this circus within your private grounds? How was that received?

Ms Bird: Distressed—distressed that there should be incursion in or near the memorial garden and distressed that the church gardens would be covered, without permission or authority, with a whole lot of political signs, for a start. Also, I understand that the AEC people had asked the police to attend, which was handy, because the church is right beside the police station in Malvern. Some elderly parishioners found that they had free access to something that is a worship centre, whatever it is at the time of elections. And there was distress that there was a disregard that, apart from being a voting centre, it is a worship centre. We really want to serve and give free licence to the community to exercise their rights. At the first instance, it's a place of worship, and it doesn't hurt to be respectful of that.

CHAIR: Were there some within your congregation who conveyed to you or to the leadership that you shouldn't be a voting centre in the future?

Ms Bird: No. This submission was made in conjunction and consultation with the parish. At St George's we regard this as a service to the community, and we've been serving the community of Malvern for more than 150 years. I act as a pastoral care worker, say, to Cabrini Malvern. We do a lot of outreach, and this particular function—allowing people to come to a place that is easily accessible, with lots of public transport and good disability facilities—we regard as, apart from everything else, being a service to the community that we've served for decades now.

CHAIR: Thank you. Any more questions?

Senator GROGAN: I have a quick one. Is your submission on behalf of the Anglican church?

Ms Bird: We've got to be careful about that.

Senator GROGAN: Yes, that's why I just wanted to—

Ms Bird: It's the Anglican parish of St George's. It happens to be an Anglican church, but the people who are in charge indirectly and have authority over the property in an Anglican church are the wardens. So, please, this isn't a statement from the Anglican church.

Senator GROGAN: No, no—I just wanted to be clear.

Ms Bird: It is from this parish that proceeded and consented to entering into a licence agreement with the AEC, so the focus is that a landowner enters into—

Senator GROGAN: That's fine. I'm aware that we're well over time.

Ms Bird: Sorry.

Senator GROGAN: Just really quickly—in terms of your agreement with the AEC, were there any explicit clauses within the agreement that you signed with them about any utilisation of the broader property, as opposed to just the facility and the six meters?

Ms Bird: No. We realised that you could only enter into an agreement with the AEC to the limit of what they can do. The licence agreement, which is set out by the Anglican Diocese of Melbourne—we're subject to them, but it's an agreement, essentially, with St George's—is that they're not allowed to cause a nuisance, for instance, to neighbouring property. They have to comply with the terms of the licence agreement, which is notifying us if there's any damage or if there's any—

Senator GROGAN: Again, that's from your perspective.

Ms Bird: Yes.

Senator GROGAN: If they're contracting you, I'm more interested in what we can maybe have some influence over, as in what the AEC might be putting forward. I look at the map that you provided us with, and you can't get there without crossing property that's not within the licence of the agreement.

Ms Bird: Well, technically—the church hall, which is the voting centre, would probably be about 10 metres from the front of Glenferrie. In fact, I'm inviting you to go and actually have a look at the site.

Senator GROGAN: To be honest, the map was really helpful, because it's very clear there that that's the situation.

Ms Bird: Yes.

Senator GROGAN: That's fine.

CHAIR: Mr Burnell.

Mr BURNELL: I want to clarify the map.

Ms Bird: Yes.

Mr BURNELL: I think it's a little bit unclear on the top of the page, but it is my understanding, from looking at Google Maps, that the top there is not a road; that is actually another property.

Ms Bird: Yes. That's a neighbouring property, all along there.

Mr BURNELL: Just for clarification, how high is the fence that essentially guards the memorial garden?

Ms Bird: It's a normal, standard paling fence along there.

Mr BURNELL: So chest height, halfway up, a metre, 1.2 metres?

Ms Bird: Normal paling-fence height.

Senator GROGAN: There are many kinds of 'normal'.

Ms Bird: Sorry about that—it's about six foot high.

Mr BURNELL: So there is a clearly identified fence to say: please do not come in here.

Ms Bird: Yes, but also, if you have a look at that map, you see the entrance to the garden of remembrance marked on that map—and I've sustained that because that was what went with the licence—and there is a sign in front of it. It's fenced off quite clearly, and there's a sign in front of it that indicates what it is.

CHAIR: Thank you. We might have to end it there. Mr Toncich.

Mr Toncich: Before I get into the bits that I prepared—I've been listening to some of the other comments. I'm an elector in the division of Goldstein. I've lived in Goldstein my whole life. I've been a member of the ALP since I could vote, and I'm passionate about electoral matters. I'll get that out of the way.

Senator GROGAN: Please take as long as you like!

Mr Toncich: At the 2022 Victorian state election we had very similar levels of abuse. I think it was Zoe Daniel volunteers who were speaking earlier about some of the abuse that they copped at the same prepoll centre in Brighton. At the 2022 Victorian state election, Labor Party volunteers absolutely copped it. Now, part of that would have been as a result of the fact that this was a post-COVID state election and there had been a very controversial policy framework around COVID in Victoria. Regardless, the level of abuse that was directed at Labor Party volunteers at that election was completely unacceptable. I hope that little extra piece of information is helpful in demonstrating to the committee a broader trend.

I've come to talk about something different today, which is when you enter the centre at the end of the day to do the scrutineering. I want to talk about some of the issues that I had when I was doing that on election day, and, with the trend that we're observing of more early votes and prepoll votes, why I think it's a bit concerning for the proper scrutiny of the process and why I think the committee needs to look more closely at some of the grounds for applying for a prepoll early vote and make sure that they're more rigorously enforced.

I'll move on to my experience scrutineering at the voting centre at the end of the day. As the time approached six o'clock on election day, I walked into the booth ready to scrutineer—I did my form well before then—and I saw two Zoe Daniel volunteers. I saw them, when I was coming in at about 5.30 ready to scrutineer, as they were leaving the venue. I asked: 'What are you doing? You just said you were coming in to scrutineer.' The AEC officer apparently told them that there was only one scrutineer allowed per candidate at the venue and, therefore, because one was already in there, the additional two that I'd seen arrive were not allowed to scrutineer. It was just those two. I asked them to hop back inside the venue and said, 'We're going to sort this out now, because that's just not right,' if for no other reason than as a matter of principle.

During this conversation, the officer there told me that the decision that he'd made—I don't think he believed he'd made it—to reject the other two scrutineers from the venue was based on 'common sense' and that he had responsibility for managing the booth and did not believe that having one person for each count officer, as the law provides, is appropriate. I pointed him to the *Scrutineers handbook*, which states very clearly:

In an election, only one scrutineer per candidate is allowed … for each officer counting the votes during the scrutiny …

I didn't really think that you could look at statements like that and go, 'There's much room for interpretation,' and the law very much provides the same thing. This should have been the end of the argument. 'You've made a mistake, not everyone knows all of the laws, and here are what the rules are.' Unfortunately, that wasn't the end of the argument, and they continued to assert that it was going to be one scrutineer per person, using their 'commonsense' definition to say, 'We could have up to'—since there were seven candidates in Goldstein—'seven count officers, and, with seven scrutineers, that is 49 scrutineers in the venue.' I told him that, yes, that's the correct interpretation of the law but, in practice, you're not going to get 49 scrutineers in the venue. There were only three for Zoe, two for Liberal, and me—a total of six at the venue; hardly a disaster. If anything, it was more of a disaster that there weren't enough, because we didn't have one scrutineer per count officer let alone per candidate per count officer.

I asked for the matter to be escalated, and it was. The response that we got from the person, who I assume was the DRO, was that it should be the amount of issuing officers that determines the additional candidates that you're allowed. I was thinking, 'That's still wrong, but it solves our problem for now; we'll get everybody into the venue,' and I just left it there. After I had left the polling place, after the scrutiny for the House of Representatives count had concluded, or at least for the primary votes—because, unfortunately, that's as far as the Labor Party candidate in Goldstein got—I was subsequently informed that this happened in at least one other polling place in Goldstein. Who knows how many people, like those two Zoe Daniel volunteers that I saw, just left because they were told that the AEC is doing the right thing? I was very concerned that an employee of the AEC was using the words 'common sense' to erode scrutineers' rights or to not follow the rules and laws that they were obliged to as an officer under the Commonwealth Electoral Act. That was a serious concern that I identified that I really wanted to bring to the attention of the federal committee.

Moving on, my other example that I wanted to talk about was prepoll and the grounds which are required to vote early. As I'm sure most of the committee members would know, you've got to have a valid reason in order to vote early. It used to be the case that AEC officers would at least be asking people, 'Are you entitled to vote early under one of these six, seven or eight different reasons?' Realistically, for almost none of the people I know of who have prepoll voted was that question ever asked. It should be, as a matter of principle, even if the AEC is not obliged to under the law. We're seeing about 50 per cent of people using prepoll or postal voting, but it's clear, if you look at schedule 2—you can see—that's not 50 per cent of electors that are eligible to vote early.

I should mention a quick example from the past election. I've heard of a case where an elector told the AEC that they were not entitled and, instead of turning them away, the AEC officer basically kept asking them the

question until they changed their answer so that they could go in and vote. While I appreciate that the AEC has good intentions with this, they should not decide not to ask or gloss over those questions because they find them inconvenient—in terms of any voter participation metrics or something that they might be trying to hit—or because they don't want to service voters on election day. I believe this is particularly important because early and postal votes are, in my view, subject to much less scrutiny and oversight.

It's much more difficult for one person to verify, end to end, that the process is fair. As such, the uptick of people not voting on election day is particularly concerning—especially when it relates to the AEC turning a blind eye to rules which it should be following. I recommend that the parliament amend the Electoral Act to further require that the commission make reasonable inquiries when an elector requests an early vote by requiring them to produce some sort—it doesn't have to be a lot of evidence, but some sort of actual evidence to prove that they are entitled to vote early. I'm happy to go into detail about why I think that the early and postal votes are not subject to anywhere near as much scrutiny as election day votes and why we need to encourage people to vote on the day, but I'll leave it up to the committee as to if they want to ask me that question.

I'll quickly touch on one thing while I have the opportunity to appear before the committee. I want to note that our current electoral system relies on individual members of parliament voting to form a government. I think that that's a system that is, in general, in need of reform because the system, as it stands, allows the party that loses the two-party preferred vote to form a majority government. Such a result, while fortunately not an issue at this election, would be a serious injustice to a majority of Australians if the two-party preferred ever differed—or when it has differed in history—from the party the forms majority government. Because our electoral boundaries are drawn independently, there is no criteria of fairness. I'm not suggesting that a criteria of fairness be implemented, but the system should work so that, if the majority of Australians say one thing, then that's the government that they get. That's maybe a personal view that I don't think the committee is going to put much consideration or thought into, but, while I have the opportunity to put it forward, I will.

CHAIR: Sure. Senator Grogan.

Senator GROGAN: You and I could discuss that for hours, but this is not the place. So I will just ask you one swift question about the idea of limiting prepoll—let's leave postal out of it for a minute. Rather than limiting prepoll, would you have any sense of a value in making prepoll more like voting day and extending it—maybe not for a full two weeks, but having a voting period that would be more than one day but that had all the checks and balances that you believe are not currently in place?

Mr Toncich: It's probably best for me, then, to explain why I think that it's a bit of an issue to have that longer period. The short answer to your question is no.

Senator GROGAN: I wondered if it was a fundamental thing or if there was—

Mr Toncich: Yes, it's more of a fundamental thing. For early voting, it's on for two or three weeks. They might open the boxes and have them checked on the Monday, then they'll be sitting in storage for two weeks, and there's going to be less scrutiny and oversight overnight for the period of the two or three week election period. Do I think people have been going in at night and stuffing ballot boxes? No. But we need to be designing our process so that, in the future, that doesn't then happen.

Senator GROGAN: I think I get your point.

Mr Toncich: That's one of the reasons. I could go into a couple of others. But, on election day, maybe I could give that reason as to why I think it's the best—scrutiny and oversight. You walk into the boxes at 8.30. You confirm that they are empty. You watch them get sealed. You see the AEC officers write down the number. You can write down that number at the end. Everybody's got eyes on that box for the whole day and the only people who are putting papers in that box are the people who got their ballot paper at the voting centre. They put it in the box and then it's unsealed at 6 pm, and you get to check that the seal numbers are exactly the same. They're unticked and counted, and you can get a full sense of how people voted on the day.

It also means that our election count process doesn't drag on for weeks and it's quicker—Zoe Daniel's electorate went from Independent retained to Liberal. Then there was the Bradfield result, which was Independent to Liberal to Independent in the end, in terms of how the media called the result. We would've had a much clearer idea of what was going on if more people had voted on the day. We would've had a greater sense of what the trend was.

CHAIR: I'm going to have to end you there—

Mr Toncich: My apologies.

Senator GROGAN: I will just defend the AEC here and say I have total confidence in the fact that those boxes are kept—

Mr Toncich: Yes, and I don't want to insist otherwise. Maybe the thing is that we trust the AEC now but we need to make sure that the process is fair.

CHAIR: Thank you very much for your evidence. Have we got Ms Bachrach and Mr Stephen? We've got four people and 30 minutes, so, if there is an ability to shorten it, that'd be great. Ms Bachrach, do you have any comments to make on the capacity in which you appear before the committee?

Ms Bachrach: I'm here in my capacity as the former Jewish liaison for Zoe Daniel. I do want to thank you very much for holding this hearing, and I want to thank my colleagues for testifying.

As you could tell from my accent, I'm an Australian citizen originally from the United States. I've been active in politics my whole life, most recently as Zoe Daniel's liaison with the Jewish community. After living in the US, participating in Australian politics has been a great relief. Imagine the pride I feel, living in a country where voting is compulsory and where partisan redistribution is replaced by the presence of an independent AEC. At my citizenship ceremony in Western Australia, I was directly immediately after receiving my certificate to the other side of the room, where my voter enrolment was already filled out except for my signature. I could hardly believe my eyes.

Yet never have I experienced the bullying, lies and intimidation my colleagues and I endured through the 2025 Goldstein campaign. I know you've heard a lot about this; when I wrote this, I didn't know. I've never been afraid to show up at prepoll, sport a T-shirt or show a bumper sticker, but this time, every day, I looked to see whether my candidate's poster had been vandalised, as so many had.

I've been politically active for a long time, and you know that you win some, you lose some and that people disagree. But, although I am loath to raise this issue during the current atmosphere, never have I, as a Jew, experienced such intra-antisemitism as I did from fellow Jews during this campaign. The weaponisation of the Israel-Gaza issue by proxy groups and the opposition resulted in a fracturing of the Jewish community that is still having ramifications. I am afraid to speak my mind today for fear of retribution. I had to dig deep inside for the wherewithal to show up to the lightning-rod polling booth in Brighton every single day for two weeks to face the onslaught of inflammatory charges that I was a self-hating Jew and a supporter of a terrorist. Australia must stand up to this before it slides into American-style polarisation and threats against polling officials.

The proxy-group volunteers claimed to back no specific candidate, but we saw them, as you've heard, swapping T-shirts with Tim Wilson's volunteers. More to the point, ADVANCE Australia is a partisan research project of the Institute of Public Affairs, where Tim Wilson served as a director. Repeal the Teal was co-founded by a founder of J-United, an activist group and explicit partner of ADVANCE. The other co-founder is a declared Liberal. The Better Australia website is sponsored by A Hirst, Liberal, Canberra. The claim that these organisations did not back a specific candidate is false and points to the need for truth in public advertising.

The atmosphere was so toxic that, in addition to creating a sunshine squad—of which I was a member—to provide moral support, we also engaged a volunteer who was a psychologist and an expert in war-zone trauma to provide debriefing. What? Polling booths should not be battlegrounds. Voting is compulsory in this democratic country, and we need to make sure that people can access the polling booths safely. Proxy groups should be banned from all poll sites; be allowed to campaigned only on issues, not on candidates; and be required to declare their sponsors, donors and spending in real time.

The campaign abuse began well before prepoll. At the candidates forum in Brighton synagogue, a Better Australia truck was parked across the street displaying a huge, distorted and deceptive sign against Zoe. The opposition supporters interrupted and booed Zoe incessantly. Shamefully, the opposition candidate made no effort to establish civil behaviour among his supporters, which really goes to the question of a pledge and a code of conduct.

Why would I bring a Jewish community matter to this committee? The committee should recommend that the AEC have scope to take up and dispatch complaints about candidate, volunteer and electoral conduct in real time. I understand the issues that have been raised today. If it can't be the AEC then another entity should be established. If there were ever an anti-democratic, anti-free-speech and coercive electoral campaign, this was it. In terms of the question about penalties, if a volunteer is out of line, I suggest that the volunteer be suspended. Australia needs to decide if it wants to go down the path of bigotry, hatred and antagonistic elections, as the US is, or if it wants to cherish its more democratic traditions and civilised debate. Government must restore social cohesion and protect civilised behaviour during our otherwise exemplary and precious elections.

CHAIR: Thank you for your courage in coming and speaking to our committee. I can't imagine what it would have been like. I have one question. You referenced the US and their hyperpolarisation. Are you seeing us on a path towards that if the government doesn't intervene?

Ms Bachrach: A fast path.

CHAIR: You're urging the government to take action on this matter so that we don't end up like that?

Ms Bachrach: Promptly.

CHAIR: That's all I had. Any other questions?

Ms Bachrach: I have a question.

CHAIR: I don't know if it works that way, but we'll give it a go.

Ms Bachrach: If my colleagues don't get to testify or if we have more to add, can we submit by 28 November?

CHAIR: We're closing submissions on 14 November for this year, but the committee will continue into 2026, and submissions will reopen. It's very likely we'll actually come back to Victoria and Melbourne—not in this same location—at another time. We're just waiting for the sitting calendar. So there will be more opportunity to write a submission in 2026. Mr Stephen.

Mr Stephen: Good afternoon, members and senators. Thank you very much for the opportunity. My objective today is to share a couple of personal anecdotes from my experience during the last federal election and for you to understand my background and what I bring to those observations. I come from a political family. I've now been campaigning actively for in excess of six decades. I started when my father was elected to the state parliament in 1964, delivering pamphlets as a child. I've campaigned in pretty much every federal and state election since. That was for the Country Liberal Party and then the Liberal Party, and the last six campaigns I have been involved with the community independent candidates.

Things changed in 2025. I can't say that there was an election cycle or an election experience that was actually like 2025. We're all listening and reflecting on the 50th anniversary of the constitutional crisis in 1975. Two things struck me, listening to new insights, reports and analysis of that crisis. The first was that that really was a crisis, and yet it was peaceful. There was not personal animosity. The other reflection was on how I heard it. One of my very good friends at school, John, broke the news to me, and John was the son of the future ALP member for our local area. That was how we did things: one of my very good friends was a political foe.

I acknowledge the work of the committee too. Senate committees and joint committees have morphed and developed a lot over the years. It's a very good example of how democracy can develop very productively and very importantly. So I acknowledge the work that you have done and are doing.

There are two anecdotes I want to share with you. The first one relates to something that occurred within 100 metres of where we sit and meet today. That was at the Kew prepoll centre, just up the road, in High Street. I was the prepoll captain on four days in the prepoll period, twice in the first week and twice in the second week. The first week was characterised by being largely like the normal mess that prepoll has become. It unfolded in a fairly typical sort of way. You actually introduce yourself to the other lead organisers. It breaks the ice, and you can all have your democratic say. So the first week worked pretty much as the normal messy prepoll process. The second week was fundamentally different, and it was different all of a sudden. It was characterised by a number of things. People had changed. There was an influx of people who seemed to be quite distinctively dressed. It then manifested itself by a complete flooding of the zone by both people and signage, to a quite extreme extent. In the first week, we were managing the fact that there's a tram stop right outside the polling booth. We would organise our signs and positioning so people could easily access public transport. In the second week, that was basically inoperative because of the extent to which the signage was out of control. The public, of course, are absolutely bereft by how that unfolds and what sort of experience it offers to them. So that's the first anecdote I want to share with you. I emphasise that these are all personal, direct, firsthand observations, so none of this is second-hand.

The second example I want to share with you is from some six weeks before the election. I was a doorknocking leader, and we were in Toorak on a Sunday afternoon at 1 pm, just gathering—a group of about six of us. A white BMW cruised past and stopped just beside us on the footpath. The driver wound down the passenger-side window and proceeded to yell out of that window at us. It started with a strong expletive and finished with, 'You don't belong here.' That was then repeated a second time: 'Bugger off. You don't belong here.' The window goes up and the car speeds off. It is quite an out-of-body experience when that sort of thing happens, and it is testament, I think, to the fact that—you will have heard a lot of evidence, I know, but they are two anecdotes I wished to share with you firsthand as to why 2025 was very different to any other election I've participated in.

CHAIR: Thank you, Mr Stephen. Does anyone have any questions?

Dr RYAN: I might recuse myself.

CHAIR: Okay. You've been doing this a while. I'd imagine you'd know the limitations of the Electoral Commission and the protections afforded to citizens to participate in democracy. From your experience, what do you feel would be the best way to return to 2022 and that better experience for voters and volunteers? How would you address it?

Mr Stephen: There are two things I would offer. One is the Victorian state system of controlling the number of signs. I think that is quite effective and quite reasonable. Politics is a winner-takes-all game, and, if you're in it, you're in it to win it. I think that you sometimes get drawn down a pathway of trying to match behaviour because it is a winner-takes-all game. If there's a clear regulation enforced that says that, at any polling place including prepolling places, you can only have X number of signs, that would be a very worthwhile initiative.

The other thing is the perimeter within which the AEC has authorisation. At a lot of booths, which, of course, are compromises in many circumstances—like the Kew prepoll on a very narrow footpath with footpath furniture, with postboxes—it was a very awkward thing to enforce the six-metre rule. I would recommend that that is increased to at least some extent. Then there is some better way for AEC officers to be supported to enforce that.

CHAIR: Thanks, Mr Stephen.

Mr Stephen: Thanks very much.

CHAIR: I call Simon Cox.

Mr Cox: I'm here as an individual, but I was a volunteer for Zoe Daniel, the Independent candidate for Goldstein, in both the 2022 and 2025 elections in a number of roles, particularly doorknocking.

CHAIR: Thank you. Please make your statement.

Mr Cox: I'm going to give short accounts of three incidents that build on each other and illustrate how a section of the community was misled and exploited on behalf of our main opponent. I'll then reflect on the disturbing consequences, both personal and broader, of this. My testimony obviously complements what you have heard and may hear in other submissions.

First, on the incidents, as I think was mentioned this morning, our candidate, along with a small group of supporters—I was one of them—attended the In One Voice street festival in Elsternwick, hosted by the Jewish community on a very rainy afternoon in March. Elsternwick is partly in Goldstein, and the Jewish community is an important element of the electorate. We came to join them in fellowship and to show our support for this community. We were subjected to numerous incidents of harassment. In particular, Zoe was aggressively called 'antisemite' and 'terrorist' to her face.

No. 2 was at the Brighton prepoll. I was standing in our supporter line outside the entrance to the polling place, about three metres outside the chalk line. Directly opposite, about two metres away from me, was a line of supporters of our main opponent. They were clearly identifiable by their candidate and party T-shirts. One of our opponent's supporters was a woman very ostentatiously fingering her Magen David—that's the Star of David—pendant, pushing it in the faces of queueing voters with the question: 'Are you Jewish? You must vote for Tim.'

No. 3 was also at the Brighton prepoll. A voter in the line, passing me and wearing my candidate's T-shirt, said, loud enough for me to hear, very deliberately, 'She's an antisemite.' I asked, 'Where did you hear that?' His response was, 'Do you know any Jews?', to which I was able to answer, 'Yes, I'm married to one.' His comeback was, 'Does she know you're here?' to which I answered, 'Yes, she was here herself half an hour ago.' His final word was, 'Then you can tell her she's a self-hating Jew.'

Now, to reflections. In the first place, the assertion that our candidate was antisemitic or a terrorist is clearly defamatory and demonstrably untrue. There is no credible evidence to support this. Zoe had gone out of her way to publicly provide practical support to the Jewish community throughout her term in office, particularly during the difficult period following the shameful Hamas attacks of 7 October 2023.

The more general point is about negative campaigning and advertising. The proliferation of the utter falsehoods distributed in print, claimed in quotes in articles in mainstream media, presented in leaflets and anonymous mailings, magnified and accelerated by social media, and spread by word of mouth—inside particularly tight social networks, in some cases—contaminates the democratic process in Australian elections. Claims about opposing candidates—their positions, track records, funding sources et cetera—must be evidence based and truthful, with prompt and significant consequences if violated. It's interesting to note that Tasmania, at least, regulates the use of an opposing candidate's image and name in campaign material. I suggest this is something

that could and should be implemented more broadly and would essentially force election advertising to be positive, not negative. It would largely remove the opportunity for attack ads.

Stepping back, the assertion that all members of the Jewish community must align with one political party and that any Jew who doesn't is therefore a traitor to the community, and thus arguably not a Jew, is a huge concern. This insults and alienates those such as my wife who supported a different candidate to the one the Jewish community leadership had chosen to endorse. Such intra-communal abuse is shocking and deeply hurtful to her and other Jews who don't fall into line. My wife is a proud Jew, to the extent that she spent two years in seminaries studying to be a rabbi. With her, I had been a regular attendee at services at a local synagogue. We've now had to resign from this, largely because of the community's intolerance of divergent views on faraway issues.

The alignment of a religious or cultural community exclusively with one political party is antidemocratic and dangerous. Identity communities can and should campaign strongly on issues relating to their interests, but political parties and candidates for office cover a variety of positions on behalf of a much broader constituency and can never be tied strongly to narrow identity communities. Where does that community stand when the party they have aligned themselves with exclusively is not in power?

I recognise this critique is primarily a matter for the leadership of the community in question, but I implore them to recognise the risks in this strategy. It is appalling that, in this city, where almost every Jew is either related to or knows someone who is a Nazi count, there would be a suggestion that someone must identify themselves publicly as a Jew, at the place of the election, and be told how to behave.

Finally, I ask all political parties and candidates to step back from the temptation to exploit a community that is feeling under stress for narrow, unrelated and short-term electoral gains.

CHAIR: Thank you very much. I call on Witness 1. Our next witness has requested to give evidence anonymously. Their evidence will be broadcast and entered into the *Hansard*. However, I am directing those present here today that no photos, videos or other recording may be taken for the duration of this witness's evidence. Failure to comply with this direction may be found to be a contempt of the parliament.

Witness 1: I've asked to be anonymous because I am Jewish and I fear for my safety and security within my community, should what I have to say be widely broadcast within my community and attached to my name.

Today I want to tell you all about an incident I experienced while volunteering for Zoe Daniel's campaign for Goldstein. While I experienced many instances of poor and problematic behaviour, there was one particular instance that I want to highlight here today. It happened while I was volunteering at the Brighton Early Voting Centre, St Stephen's Anglican Church. I was there when far-right provocateur Avi Yemini arrived and planted someone in the voting line to accost and berate me while filming. As memories can be fickle things, I'll read for you verbatim a message that I sent to friends right after the incident occurred. It reads as follows: 'I was involved against my will in an Avi Yemini stunt today. I don't think I gave him what he wanted, so it probably won't be published, but it was kinda scary. Someone in line to vote, a plant asked me, "Have you heard what Zoe said about antisemitism?" and I said, "Yes, absolutely. I'm Jewish, so"—and he cut me off and said, "Oh, so you're a fuckwit, then," really intensely. His tone totally changed from genuine to trying to create a reaction in me. The team around me was great, and I'm totally fine and handled it calmly, but yeah, wow, yikes.' End message.

The 2025 election was my first time volunteering for a campaign, and it is worrying to think of the number of passionate volunteers for any candidate who no longer want to volunteer due to experiences like this. In many ways, I was really lucky. The intention was to record a strong reaction from me in order to try and show the Zoe Daniel campaign in a negative light, but it didn't work. I was fortunate that day to have a great team around me and the support of other voters, strangers in the line, and managed to contain myself and to not give the sort of reaction that they were looking for. Not everyone will have been so lucky. It is those without that sort of support who are in need of it most.

I don't know how to stop provocateurs trying to disrupt the election process. However, I have some suggestions for perhaps how to help at a higher level. I ask the committee to consider the pros and cons of restricting the ability to campaign near polling booths to nominated volunteers of candidates, similar to the way scrutineers are nominated; I support the calls made earlier today for a mandatory candidate code of conduct to give us something to point at and say was broken; I support the forming of a new body alongside the AEC to have jurisdiction over campaign activities outside of the six-metre boundary booths; and I strongly support truth in political advertising being the law, as it is in South Australia, to help lower the heat during an election period. Thank you.

CHAIR: Thank you, Witness 1. Do we have any questions?

Dr RYAN: I have some questions. Thank you for your testimony. I'm sorry that you had that experience. When you were approached by Avi Yemini, presumably he had a cameraman with him.

Witness 1: I wasn't actually approached by Avi Yemini. Avi was behind the line, and the cameraperson was behind the line from where I was standing, and the line was moving between me and Avi and the cameraperson.

Dr RYAN: Okay, so you were probably outside the six-metre line.

Witness 1: Yes, we were all outside the six-metre line.

Dr RYAN: And this happened at a prepoll?

Witness 1: This was at Brighton prepoll, yes.

Dr RYAN: Thank you. To protect people from this—because I think probably lots of people experience unpleasant intrusions related to media people being at prepoll and approaching people, sometimes in ways that they would prefer not to be approached—should we be putting limits on the media's activities or on the volunteers' activities?

Witness 1: Perhaps we should be putting limits on the media activities. I hadn't fully thought that point through. I was just thinking about what would have happened or what could have happened if I didn't have the team that I had around me and how to support the volunteers of smaller campaigns that don't have that team around them.

Dr RYAN: Thank you.

CHAIR: I really appreciate the time that you've given us today and your courage in giving evidence before the committee. That goes to everyone here today. Thank you for your time. I recognise that some people have been here since the very beginning. As I said earlier, I'm pretty confident that we'll come back to Melbourne next time round, so, if you haven't been able to give evidence verbally today, you can do so again in the new year. But, of course, please also consider giving a written submission.

Committee adjourned at 15:00